

The orienteering king” becomes a legend

THIERRY GUEORGIU

Thierry Gueorgiou as seen by his teammates and his coaches p. 24

Thierry Gueorgiou From record holder to legend p. 4

The orienteering news - Special Issue

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Thierry Gueorgiou in videos

The last run of the King of Orienteering :<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Av55S7bmMBo>
Running Wild Orienteering (The New York Times)

:<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H3TLmTNOB5E>

Follow me, Thierry Gueorgiou in Cervara :<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=bwRdLWEqFI>

Orienteering World Champion Thierry Gueorgiou and his passion for night orienteering

:<https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=WVcdD9yIO3I>

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We all knew that the fantastic career of Thierry Gueorgiou in the French team would eventually come to an end. With this in mind, the publishers of the French Orienteering Magazine decided some time ago that, after his last race in French colours, a whole issue would be dedicated to Thierry.

The time that everyone was dreading has finally arrived and we can no longer look forward to the enjoyment and excitement of Thierry's performances and achievements in the coming seasons.

Over the years, Thierry has made us all very proud. His performances have been celebrated throughout the orienteering world. Leaving with a final world title was the high point of his career -legendary!

This special issue of the French Orienteering Magazine is an opportunity to thank Thierry for all that he has brought to our country and to orienteering in France. We invite you to revisit his 14 World titles, and also to discover Thierry from a different perspective - that of his former coaches and teammates. We hope that you enjoy this magazine and join me in sending Thierry a great...

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Michel Ediar and Thierry Gueorgiou

Colossal Thierry !

SPECIAL ISSUE

THANK YOU

Michel EDIAR, President of the French Orienteering Federation

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Fourteen-time world champion Thierry Gueorgiou will no longer be at the heart of orienteering. Initially a specialist in middle distance orienteering, he quickly became dominant in most of the disciplines, making him the most successful competitor in the history of the sport. At the age of 38, and as his career is coming to an end, it is an appropriate moment for us to look back, in depth, at his incredible journey.

Thierry Gueorgiou was born on 30 March 1979 in Saint-Etienne. A hyperactive child, who couldn't stay in one place for more than five minutes, he started orienteering with his parents. At that time orienteering was just a big playground for this born competitor, who could not stop until he won.

The first years of his life were as a member of NOSE (the St-Etienne orienteering club) where his parents, Marie-Christine and Michel, were at that time rapidly taking on more and more responsibility. As young children, we do not really choose a sport, but simply go along with the family and, for Thierry, nothing was better than playing games after the races with his brother, Rémi, and Olivier, Laure and Magali (the children of the Coupât family).

Biography

1987

Thierry first dreams of

becoming a world champion

A first insight came in 1987, when he was 8 years old. Thierry had no idea that anyone could orienteer better than his older brother (by 3 years) and had never heard those important 3 letters W-O-C (World Orienteering Championships) which were to become such a major part of his life.

It was in that year that France first organi-sed the world championships at Gérardmer.

Thierry Gueorgiou FROM RECORD HOLDER TO LEGEND

A born competitor from an early age

Thierry with his brother Rémi (left)

By Gabrielle Parfait

Thierry was there and chased the Nordic orienteering stars for their autographs. The star of Swedish orienteer Kent Olsson shone brightly at the event and he won the individual race.

Thierry's curiosity was awakened when he saw Kent's teammates toss him into the air to celebrate his victory. Looking on, Thierry was envious and the seeds of his future were sown....

But it was four years later; during the spectator races at the world championships in 1991 in Czechoslovakia that Thierry's dream finally took shape. He won a race in H11. Because this competition took place at the same time as the "real" world championships, Thierry thought that he was world champion ... H11!

When he returned to school at the beginning of the school year, he proudly announced (to the amusement of his classmates) that they should now see him as the best in the world. On the way home from school, he formulated a dream that would never leave

The Scandinavian countries, role models

French orienteering in the 1990s was far away from the level of the Scandinavians. The sport there had been established for thirty years, and we had neither their culture of training, nor their structure. Thierry was to benefit from the great passion of his father who quickly learned Swedish and Norwegian to better understand their specific training methods. Every summer was devoted to visiting these countries with the objective of understanding their daunting terrain and their best young orienteers.

Also at that time, Michel Gueorgiou was offered the position of national coach, and was able to bring the training methods used at the club level in NOSE to the national stage. His basic philosophy was simple: "no training without a map". He developed an innovative simulation method to overcome the fact that the training areas around Saint-Etienne were

be developed by concentrating exclusively on the quality of map reading. In the forest, Olivier Coupat started to deliver good performances helping to overcome the inferiority that we felt to the Swiss or the Scandinavians and paving the way for others to follow. His progress was, unfortunately, slowed by a serious knee injury.

1998

The French high level

On 11 December 1998, Pôle France was created in Saint-Etienne by then Federation and National technical director Jean-Luc Toussaint. The French objective was simple: catch up by taking inspiration from the Scandinavian approach and push the level of excellence even further.

Although there was work to do, French orienteers had the great benefit of training and running on high quality maps of very different

Kent Olsson at WOC 1987

Thierry at the Bohemia 5 Days, 1991

NOSE training camp in Norway with the Coupats, 1991

Training on the top of Mont Pilat (Saint-Etienne)

Laure & Olivier Coupat celebrate their 6th place in the 1996 World Cup

des rochers, Les Escarcets, Vilhosc, Le Rocher de l'éléphant). Travel to the four corners of France increased; there was no time to lose!

Thierry, meanwhile, had settled in his chosen sport, putting handball, which he also liked, and cross-country skiing that he practised at school aside.

It was during these early years of first events and competitions with the France cadets team and then the French junior team, that Thierry made friends for life. A whole generation grew up together: his childhood friend François Gonon, and also Damien Renard, Jean-Baptiste Bourrin, Benoît Peyvel, Matthieu Puech, and many others. This group bonded together, and even created a club, The Team, allowing for even more fun time together.

At the 1998 junior world championships, the group first showed its strength & depth, winning the first medals in the history of the FFCO - the first in long distance by Thierry and, importantly, the bronze medal in the relay.

The story had begun but Thierry still had to competition. His physical abilities were good but not exceptional; he wanted to be able to win like his childhood idol Kent Olsson - with his head more than with his legs. This quickly became his trademark and his volume of training "with map in hand" was the highest of the high level orienteers.

A career that almost did not see

the light of day

In 2000, Thierry decided to spend more time in Scandinavia, with the best orienteers in the world. He joined Kalevan Rasti, a club based in the city of Joensuu in eastern Finland, to prepare for the 2001 world championships, which were to be held in Finland.

His goal was to get into the top 10 in the world, and to continue climbing one by one. But this championship led to a turning point in his sporting career. He finished 18th in the middle distance. He left the finish area with his head down, lost in thought and unable see a way forward. His race had been practically perfect, but he had finished more than three minutes behind the formidable Finnish winner, Pasi Ikonen, one year his junior. It was, therefore, not just a matter of age, but a matter of skill. For the first time, he questioned his ability to become world champion, and started to think that he was aiming, in his own words, "simply too high, and too far ". The following summer was painful, his frustration such that he would not pick up a map for two months. His story was in danger of falling apart.

One man, Kalevan Rasti coach Börje Vartiainen, put him back on track, with some simple advice.

He had understood before Thierry what the real issue was. Thierry's technique was excellent, but inefficient. He was trying to take in too much information from the map and the ground. The solution? Simplify his orienteering by concentrating on the most important and visible elements.

Thierry memorised these words carefully, and used them to guide all his training sessions over the following winter.

Saint-Jean-Soleymieux, 1991, SHOCart

Winter Training Weekend with Pôle France, Larzac 1999

Börje Vartiainen

The Culture of Success builds

The 2002 season proved that France was closing the gap with other countries, and a golden generation had developed. Alongside excellent results obtained at university level, in particular in relays (2000 and 2002), the World Cup season saw the French on the podium for the first time with a second place in the sprint for Thierry in Norway, a third place in Sweden in an epic mass-start by François Gonon, and, the highlight, in the final of the World Cup in Czech Republic, a win by Damien Renard. History was made!

The 2003 season was essentially a continuation of the previous one. At that time, the World Cup and World Championships took place on alternate years. The Swiss alpine village of Triin hosted the World Championships middle distance competition. In suffocating heat,

Thierry ran probably his best race in a major championship. Big time gaps between runners are seldom seen at this level but Thierry won by 2' 37" from the second place runner, multi-world champion Norwegian Bjørnar Valstad, announcing his arrival on the world stage with a bang! With his success came a step change in interest -people wanted to learn as much about him as they could (including how to pronounce and write his complicated surname). Such success was all the more special as it was the last championship for Thierry's father as French orienteering team coach and was the culmination of his beliefs and development of his route to success for France. French technical expertise was now respected in the orienteering world.

The transition from "Amateur" to "Professional"

In addition to his victories for Kalevan Rasti in major Scandinavian relays, Thierry went on to extend his "kingdom" to the other distances, becoming world sprint champion in 2007, and adding world long distance and relay titles in 2011, to become the first man to

Finish of the 2000 FISU 2000 Relay in Roanne

2002 World Cup in Sweden, François Gonon 3rd in long distance

2002 World Cup in the Czech Republic, Damien Renard 1st in sprint

Thierry during the WOC 2004 middle distance
Thierry and his father
2011

WOC 2011 France :

the Apotheosis !

There can be no doubt that the master-piece of his career was Thierry's performance at the 2011 World Championships, on the home soil of the Féclaz plateau in the Savoie, where he dominated the field with a historic three victories (medium distance, to deliver to an audience, but for these races he prepared to the maximum, spending countless days training in the months before. Everything was calculated, prepared and analysed in microscopic detail in the two months leading up to the event. He also helped the Swedish team with their training and, in the process, crossed the path of a charming orienteer, Annika Billstam. His father even thought for a time that this was a Swedish team strategy to disrupt Thierry's preparations! Either way, there was a golden result - a first world title for Annika in the long distance, followed a few minutes later by the same for Thierry. Tension was highest at the last event, the relay. Everybody in the arena was aware of the French men's team experiences at recent WOC relays. In 2008, close to the finish, with France well on course to victory on the last leg, Thierry was stung by a wasp, suffered an allergic reaction and had to stop. In 2009, the leading pack of Thierry and the Norwegian and Czech runners stopped to help a Swedish runner who had suffered a serious, possibly life-threatening injury. This action earned them the prize for international fair play. In 2010, France finally believed that it would take its first world relay title. Thierry seemed unstoppable on the last leg having quickly taken the lead, but he did not see a control on the course and made a fatal mistake. The team seemed jinxed; even though logic says that: "an orienteering race is simple, it is a line, a circle, the next line, and so on." This proved to be the right approach to the problem, and finally (in 2011), with teammates François Gonon and Philippe Adamski, came the greatest emotional moment of his career, victory. Having crossed the winning line, Thierry wasted no time in acknowledging the part played by Damien Renard who has just left the French

Biography

relay triumph!

The end of a dream career

Over the years, it was ultimately the long distance in which Thierry's qualities were best displayed, winning four titles (a record) in five years (2011-2015). During that time, he had dealt with a number of annoying injuries that disrupted his preparations, but he was always present for his only appointment of the summer: the World Championships, accumulating 13 titles from 2003 onwards, the impressive average of almost a title per year!

At the end of his career, Thierry had to determine his future direction. He had a strong family - Annika retired after a last success at WOC 2015 in Scotland. He understood that nothing could replicate the experience of working side by side with his French teammates. The time had finally come to give way to the next generation. He also looked at the example of his father and the opportunity

through coaching. As a result, Thierry decided to accept the position as a coach for Sweden (the country where he now lives and where he and Annika welcomed their first child in July 2017).

For Thierry, 2017 will remain a year full of emotions, marking both the end of his sporting adventure and his first steps in his new

Thierry wins the TioMila with his club Kalevan Rasti in 2013

Thierry and Annika at the finish of the WOC 2011 long distance

Philippe, Thierry and François during the WOC 2011 relay

Léon Gueorgiou, with

Michel DROSSOFORIDIS GUEORGIOU

Marie GUEORGIOU (née NOVITCHKOV)

Nicolas GUEORGIOU Marcelle GUEORGIOU (née FRINOT)

Roger FRINOT

Rémi GUEORGIOU

Michel GUEORGIOU

Thierry GUEORGIOU

Marcel FRINOT Blanche FRINOT (née ROBIN)

Jacques BROCC Juliette BROCC (née TAULIER)

Marie-Christine GUEORGIOU (née BROCC)

In Greek, Gueorgiou means "farmer". Michel, Thierry's great-grandfather, was a native of Mesa Mouliana, a small village in Crete in the Aegean Sea. His name then was Drossoforidis, not Gueorgiou. But after his studies at the monastery of Moni Toplou, he decided to escape his destiny of becoming a monk, fled and changed his name to Gueorgiou. In Greece, Gueorgiou is the equivalent of Dupont in France (or Smith in the UK)!

The next trace of this Michel Gueorgiou is in Tashkent, then the advanced outpost of the Russian empire where he made his fortune.

He married Marie Novitchkov and had a child, Nicolas, Thierry's paternal grandfather. The Russian revolution broke out and, ruined, the couple found themselves in France where Michel (the great-grandfather) died as a result of a methane explosion in the mine where he worked.

After his military service with the Zouaves, Nicolas (the grandfather) married Marcelle Frinot, whose brother, Roger Frinot (Thierry's great-uncle), was a French javelin champion and record holder and a great admirer of the Finnish throwers. Hence, Thierry's father Michel was brought up in an environment full of the French team and medals; as a teenager his sports were javelin and running, first in Paris at Racing

Club de France, then at AS Aix-les-Bains.

After moving to Saint-Etienne to work at the city high school, Thierry's father became an athletic coach at Coquelicot. He married Marie-Christine, also a coach in Coquelicot. After the Winter Olympics in Grenoble, long distance cross-country skiing fever spread in the mountains! With no time to fit in work, training in Coquelicot and personal training, Michel gave up Coquelicot and concentrated on his training to build endurance: raids and MTB coastal race, 7:44 for the

Genealogy

100 km on road, victories in the raid Lyon-Saint-Etienne, Embrun ironman and, in winter, countless cross-country competitions in the Jura with his colleague Gérard Coupat.

It was at this time that a NOSE member knocked on Michel's door to tell him about an orienteering race the following Sunday. As luck had it, it was a Sunday free with no competitions! In no time at all, helper Régis Antoine started a supremely confident man who raced off at full speed (course less than 10 km: far too short!) and quickly caught and passed a lot of competitors who started in front of him. After a while, realising that he was completely alone, he met a man walking along a road, who explained to him that he had managed to run off the map some time ago.

What a shock! What a challenge - being forced to use his brain, while still testing his endurance. Marie-Christine, Thierry's mother, found this new sport a little messy, but it reminded her very much of the cross-country of her youth! So, Marie-Christine and Michel shared a dream to recreate, in orienteering, the environment of regular training alternating with the motivation provided by inter-club competitions that they had experienced in athletics. The boys, "Rems" and "Thier", would soon be caught up in the whirlwind that will take them far, far away!

Sportsmen : like father like son!

Some genealogy...By Michel Gueorgiou,

Thierry's father

Nowadays, with GPS tracking and television, we know almost everything about what hap-pens in the forest on D-Day, and post-race analysis is relatively simple to do. But this will always be the tip of the iceberg; good results come from good preparation done well away from the race day spectators. It is this journey that I will try to share with you here.

Since the World Championship in France in 2011, I have always had, in the back of my mind, the thought: "When to stop before it's too late? ". Too late is an abstract concept because, at the point where I am, it's not one more success (or not) which will really define my career, but more, that I want to choose when I go. And, if possible, leave through the front door. In previous years, I had always managed to postpone this question to another day, finding each year new challenges, and above all, loving so much my life as an elite sportsman, which I always considered as an unexpected extension of my childhood, away from the hassle of everyday life.

Over the last few years, seeing my compe-

Last Race

my companions along the way heading to the sidelines, I have realised that the years are passing and I am nearing the end.

2016

2016 seems to me a good year to

stop as the World Championships are in Sweden, my adopted country; although the terrains are not necessarily to my advantage. But I start my preparation thoroughly, as if it were the last. I cannot count the number of times that I travelled back and forth between Uppsala (on the east coast, where I live) and Strömstad (west coast) to give me the best chance of success. Olav Lundanes, my greatest rival this year lives about thirty kilometres arduous task, just as it was for my opponents in 2011.

My performances in this champions-hip are good (silver medal in long distance, 4th place on middle distance and 6th in relay), without being excellent. Alone in the car on my way back to Uppsala, I wonder, "Is this really the end?" "Am I already out of the game? Should I have quit after the wonderful day in Scotland in 2015?" (Editor's note: Gold medal in long distance during the World Championships).

Although it did not give me nightmares, this question plagued me for the whole of autumn, and it wasn't until the end of

WOC MIDDLE DISTANCE 2017

Thierry running for the Long Distance gold at WOC 2011 by Isabelle RORA

By Thierry GUEORGIU

ning of an answer. On the table, I have a contract to work as a coach of the Swedish team, I just have to sign it, and I will move to the other side of the fence. Instead of preparing myself for WOC 2017, I will prepare the Swedish team. It is at this moment that I feel the desire to push the path a little further.

At the same time, I learn that Annika is pregnant, and that she will give birth at the end of July, most likely two weeks after the end of WOC. I see this as a clear sign, and something that has meaning for me. I want to give myself the opportunity to experience one last adventure.

So I think "ok, let's go, one last time, but let's prepare for this one in a different way." The idea is to savour every moment of preparation, that's obvious. But I must be careful, I am not preparing for my holidays at Club Med, I am preparing for a "war"! My competitors, so to speak, "don't care about my state of mind ". So I have to be perfectly prepared for the day. But for that, I will need exceptional motivation, and I will need to make two important decisions.

2 decisions

The first is that I will announce publicly, in

December, that this is to be my last season. This will allow me to experience "cool stuff" throughout the season and to feel the emotions of the people that I have touched along my journey, but it will put me under the maximum of pressure. And pressure, if it is well managed, is a formidable driver, and that's what I'm counting on.

The second decision is to focus on a single individual race: the middle distance. The one that has always fascinated me, and which "defined" me at the highest level. This race seems to have got away from me since 2011, and although it is probably in the long distance that my qualities have best been seen over the last few years, I want to leave the stage via the same race that I entered it.

In previous winters, my preparations had been hampered by physical problems (of varying degree) so one of my goals this year was to be ultra-vigilant. The last thing I wanted was to not be able to take my chances and perform to my capability at the World Championships. I

absolutely had to avoid injury. I immediately changed my approach a little, valuing the rest periods,

Last Race

reducing the volume of training, but increasing the number of quality sessions.

Spring came quickly, and it was as I saw Annika's stomach growing that I became fully aware how close the end was, and the beginning of a new story.

The World Cup in Finland would be, at the same time, the last dress rehearsal and the beginning of the final preparations, but especially a good way to boost my confidence level. But the opposite happened, with a 17th place in the middle distance. Irrelevant and out of the game. I can't believe it. There are probably several reasons to explain this underperformance - notably tiredness after a too hard training period and a drop in my iron levels.

But above all, I have only one thing in mind, 6 July 2017, I am "programmed" and everything else is preparation. But instead of recognising this and continuing to work "quietly", I "over-react" following the (non-) performance in Finland, and invest even more. I defined my work areas: techniques, physical and mental for the home straight. There are only six weeks remaining, things can change a lot. And quickly, the feelings come back.

72 kg

Two weeks before WOC, I feel ready.

I am as sharp as possible, 72kg on the scales - one kilo less than in 2016. But most of all, I feel strong in the forest, and my technique is well in place.

Although I know that everything will be played out in the mental dimension in the run up to the event, I had rarely been so calm in the days leading up to my race. Quite simply, because of the event that was coming at the end of July and would completely change the lives of Annika and myself, I was certain that this was going to be the best summer of my life. And there was also a more personal dimension, almost selfishness, to want to do this at the same time for me, and also so that people remember me as someone who has not run *Thierry Gueorgiou WCup Finland ©Jenny Puputti*

I never stopped reminding myself that I wanted to be here, in this situation, totally committed. During the final hours before the race I could feel the tension go up a notch as I saw the number of messages that I received on my email and my mobile phone. But I was ready for all that, having streamlined the whole process.

A circle and a line

Orienteering, remains above all "a

circle, a line, a circle..." - points to find in the forest. Full stop. And I have done this practically all my life. And the atmosphere around me ie the whole French team (runners and technical staff) was just perfect. All the time they made me feel that something special was going to happen. It was just another World Championship race and I have experienced a good many.

The closer I got to the H hour, the more confident I felt, in spite of a last "wake-up call" that kept my feet on the ground and mind focused. During my last quick speed, two days before the middle distance, on the model map, I had to start again. It happens very rarely, but it's sometimes the case while training that I feel that I have to correct something immediately. My first attempt is a disaster, and I need several minutes to find the first control. It's not a question of technique or form or anything like that. It's just that I'm forgetting the fundamentals. A race always starts with the first control, and it's necessary to take the time to start the course on the right foot. There's only one chance. It is this instruction that will be highlighted on my instruction sheet that I look at during the warm up.

There is ultimately little to say, or to write, on the race itself. I made sure to live it fully. I've seen it as my retirement gift from me to myself. A last "hit" of emotions!

I want to use this article to thank everyone who has accompanied, guided or inspired me on some or all of this journey. I cannot thank you enough because the performance, even of an individual, will always be the fruit of teamwork. The road was beautiful, it was a great adventure.

Thierry Gueorgiou at the WOC Estonia MD finish

Words from the Presidents

Edmond Széchenyi 1985-2000 "An IOF official told me that Thierry would be the new star of orienteering for at least a decade."

I have followed Thierry's progress since his beginnings when he first appeared on the radar screen in a major event at the 1998 World Junior Championships in Reims, where he won two medals.

But it was in 2000, at the World University Championships in Roanne where his potential was really revealed. It was here that Thierry and Simone Luder (later Niggli) dominated the men and women respectively. Afterwards, an IOF official told me that we had found two new orienteering stars for at least the next decade. He wasn't wrong. The 2003 World Championships was for me the climax of my orienteering life: I had the privilege and joy to put his first World Champion gold medal around Thierry's neck!

Marie-France Charles 2000-2008 « The best moment of my Association life »

Memories, memories ... In 2003, our Federation sent our athletes to participate as usual, in the various world competitions. As newly elected head of the FFCO, I did not have the chance to go abroad with our competitors because we were going through a difficult financial period and it was important to me that they were our priority.

Each day, our National Technical Director, Michel Devrieux, would keep me informed of the results obtained.

One afternoon in August, my phone rang and I heard someone with a voice full of emotion saying, "Marie-France, Marie-France, we will definitely get on the podium!" Needless to say I was happy, our efforts had finally been realised and we would reap the rewards. A moment later the phone rang again, and I heard, "GOLD, we have a gold medal, Marie-France, you have finally gained a gold medal for our Federation." Pure happiness, and then, Michel and I, connected by a piece of wire thanks to Mr. Thomas Edison and separated by thousands of kilometres, both cried for joy.

Thierry has since brought us further great victories which, I assure you, are very easy to get used to. Thank you Thierry, I will never forget this beautiful moment for the rest of my life, the most important of my time as a member of the Association.

Words from the

Thierry 2nd in the Classic, JWOC 1998

Thierry, François Gonon and Jean-Baptiste Bourrin 3rd in the relay, JWOC 1998

Edmond Széchenyi leaves the podium as Thierry celebrates his victory in the WOC 2013 middle distance

2000: University World Championships

At the Élysée!

On 15 September 2003, the athletes who had distinguished themselves in their disciplines during the 2002-2003 season were received at the Élysée

Président Thierry!

Michel Edjar (since 2013) "Will Thierry continue for another season?"

Every year during the World Championships, the Presidents of the national federations are gathered together for a week, and when they don't have meetings organised by the IOF on their agenda, they are to be found in the "VIP" area of the arena. This space is a perfect place for exchanges of views, and of course a place to discuss the races in progress. As mentioned already by Edmond Széchenyi, internationally Thierry is a "global" superstar. During my first visit to the WOC in 2013, I discovered an unexpected supporter of Thierry in the person of the IOF President, Brian Porteous. For Brian, Thierry was an extraordinary champion, both from a sporting point of view as well as from a personal point of view. Sooner or later in my conversations with colleague Presidents, Thierry was always discussed, either to praise his exceptional career or for his longevity at such a high level, always with the final thought "will Thierry continue for another season?"

Between 2013 and 2017 I had the chance to encourage Thierry during his last 4 world titles. As President of the Federation, it is always an immense joy when one of our athletes wins a title and to listen to the Marseillaise and watch the rise of our blue, white and red flag when you are abroad. It is always a moment of great emotion.

Thanks again to Thierry for his fantastic career, his face will remain etched in the history of orienteering.

Jean-Paul Ters 2008-2013 "But who is Thierry Gueorgiou?"

A French sportsman known worldwide, but who remains unknown in his own country despite his seventeen world titles (including three military titles) as senior (plus the others!). What a paradox! But let's move on to the question I was asked: What are my best memories of Thierry? It's difficult to maintain even the slightest suspense, because it is obviously the three gold medals won at the 2011 WOC at La Féclaz in particularly challenging races. I particularly remember Thierry's victorious arrival at the end of a hard-fought relay, with his partners François and Philippe at his side. I will not forget the three gold medals won during the 2010 World Military Championships in Norway (with François and Frédéric in the relay), giving France its first military orienteering titles. Finally, I remember Thierry's magnificent gesture of sportsmanship to his Swedish friend Martin Johansson, who was badly injured during the third leg of the WOC 2009 relay race in Hungary.

Thierry is an exceptional champion who has always remained humble and without pretensions throughout his sporting career, remarkable for a non-professional. A small example from WOC 2011; the competitions were not over but he spontaneously agreed to spend more than one hour of his time accompanying me to the National Forestry Office stand (brought from Paris for the occasion) to talk with the forestry staff, when he still had to debrief, rest and prepare for the next race.

I wish him a brilliant future professional career among us. Thank you Thierry for the prestige you have brought to France and for the example that you gave to millions of young athletes around the world.

Presidents

The very last medal of an extraordinary career: Michel Ediar with Thierry and the WOC 2017 silver medal-winning French relay team

Thierry Gueorgiou and Jean-Paul Ters at the end of their visit to the booth of the National Forest Office, after the final of the middle distance. (photo: Claude Bouveresse, ONF Chambéry, August 19, 2011)

It was in the spring of 2000 that Thierry signed for the Finnish club Kalevan Rasti. The club quickly joined the ranks of the world's elite clubs and has stayed there for almost 20 years. It is an exceptional symbiosis between a sports club and a unique personality that has resulted in an extraordinary success story.

Thierry Gueorgiou received an email from Kalevan Rasti in autumn 1999 and joined the club in Spring 2000. As Finns, we were unable to pronounce his name so we immediately gave him a Finnish one: Tero Kettunen. Kettunen comes from "Kettu" which means "fox". The fox is an animal of the forest, intelligent and clever. Just like this "fox".

Kalevan Rasti was founded in 1950 in the city of Joensuu, capital of eastern Finland with 70 000 inhabitants. In 1999, our objective was to set up an international-level team.

In 1983, a team of boys, all from Joensuu had won the TioMila. But by the year 2000 it was impossible. The world had become smaller thanks to the Internet and the use of English, which greatly aided the organisation of competitions and training camps. We had also noticed that more and more high-level athletes were not from the Nordic countries. In France, there were two exceptionally young and talented athletes: Thierry Gueorgiou the "great" and François Gonon, the "little one."

The Jukola is the largest, the most beautiful, the most important.

For Finnish clubs, the Jukola is something
Finland

of the legendary adventures of seven brothers on a beautiful summer night.

Since the first Jukola in 1949, the event has grown to more than 15,000 participants and attracts unparalleled media coverage. The dream of any Finnish orienteering club is to win the Jukola. Upon his arrival at the club, we made Thierry understand: the Jukola is the biggest, the most beautiful and the most important of all relays in the world!

Kalevan Rasti had been close to victory several times and in 2004, for the first time, a foreigner was chosen to run the last leg, because he had become (and still was) world champion in middle distance the previous year.

The deciding last leg of the 2004 relay was the occasion of a memorable duel between Thierry and Emil Wingstedt, the last runner from Halden. We all knew that Emil was a better runner than Thierry. Thierry had run behind Emil for more than 15 km, waiting for him to make an error; an error that never came. When they arrived in sight of the Finish area, it seemed that the cause was lost. But the surprise came when, at the penultimate control, Thierry suddenly sprinted on the last descent. It was way too early and Emil did not immediately realise what was happening and

saw the distance which remained to the finish line, as he had already exceeded his sprinting capability and his entire body was full of lactic acid! He snatched a quick glance behind him and saw that Emil had been so totally surprised that he had resigned himself to second place.

It was a victory of "mind over matter" because Thierry absolutely wanted to win this relay! For all in Kalevan Rasti, this moment was a shock, something unforgettable: everyone was shouting, laughing, crying! The most beautiful dream of the club had become reality: we had won the Jukola!

By Urpo Väänänen, author of the 1999 e-mail intended to recruit Thierry to Kalevan Rasti
Kalevan Rasti wins Jukola

Thierry and his Finnish fans, Urpo Väänänen and his son Villi, WOC 2011
Thierry in the colours of Kalevan Rasti, 2015

Kalevan Rasti and Tero Kettunen: a long and beautiful history of orienteering!

It was a total surprise and, at the same time, felt a bit strange because it was a young Frenchman who was responsible for the victory in the most prestigious competition in Finland. After this event, everyone knew how to pronounce Thierry's name ...

The "bottle of ketchup" of the Juko was uncorked in 2004!

www.youtube.com/watch?v=2ULXzY8wdGA

From that point, the process of "march of the team in red" continued: Kalevan Rasti won the Jukola five times (and finished in the first three on three further occasions) and the Swedish TioMila three times. And in the total rankings of the Jukola, Thierry has the highest score of all time!

Between 2003 and 2016, Thierry was repeatedly world champion and he became, without any doubt, the best orienteer in the world. As the end of his high-level career approaches, we can only wonder how it was possible. What has he received from and what has he given to this club where he has lived in harmony for 20 years? Why has he not changed club, despite many demands? Thierry is certainly exceptionally talented, and he has managed to come back after each of his injuries, but it's his passion for the sport of orientee-ring that would have led him, even without Kalevan Rasti, to the top of the world. It is not in the nature of the Finnish character to boast. On average, a Finn speaks less than twice as many words as a Frenchman! We are the best in the world for modesty and it is difficult for us to say to what extent Kalevan Rasti has helped Thierry. But it is undeniable that Kalevan Rasti has magnificent terrain and quality maps, and above all recognised expertise in the field of training. Thierry especially benefited from 2000 when he spent long periods in Joensuu. The club has

on the essentials. The many discussions with Börje Vartiainen, Jukka Inkeri, Antti Harju, and others have benefited the technical progress of many. But it's above all with Börje that Thierry found more than a friend: a perfectionist, like him, capable of reflecting, even while asleep, on how to improve. For Thierry, the fact is that, during the last ten years, he has been able to understand the evolution of elite orienteering faster than everyone else, without sacrificing the daily routine of his physical training.

In Kalevan Rasti, he has friends who are always ready to help. For some of us he is like our son. Friendships for life have been made. Money has little place in these relationships, but it cannot be ignored, and behind Kalevan Rasti is a foundation that supports the elite team and which has made it possible to maintain the quality of the results of the flagship team year after year. But the sums are nothing compared to those available for professional sports.

Kalevan Rasti has international recognition thanks to Thierry

Kalevan Rasti has benefited greatly from this symbiosis thanks to Thierry's character and personality. He communicates easily and his passion for orienteering is contagious. Upon arrival at the club, this phenomenon was immediately apparent. It may be hard to believe, but Kalevan Rasti has never sought to recruit foreign runners. They asked to come, normally they asked through Thierry, even though they were already medalists in international competitions. This is how a club in this small town in Karelia became known internationally with the recruitment of Frenchman Philippe Adamski, Swiss Fabian Hertner and Baptiste Rollier, the Czechs Jan Prochazka and Jan Petrzela, Bulgarian Kiril Nikolov and recently Britain's Graham Gristwood. Almost all are medalists at world championships! This was not foreseen in 1999! It is also thanks to Thierry that several high-level Martomaa, Mikael Boström, Miika Hernelahti, Simo-Pekka Fincke and Antti Harju.

The club knew how to avoid internal quarrels

But perhaps most importantly has been that, for almost 20 years, we have avoided internal quarrels in the club (despite the difficult choices that had to be made) regarding the composition of the teams even with the strong personalities of these competitors. They all wanted to be in the boat but no one made it capsize. This is very unusual, because often the demise of a club starts with internal quarrels.

A top athlete must often make selfish choices if he wants to be the best in the world. Thierry has always known how to control these susceptibilities, and his happy character has avoided

many conflicts. When he retires, a new era will begin for him. Our intention is not to be sad, but to remember and be proud of the many collective successes. We all know that he will not stop orienteering and that we will see him again fighting for victory in the Jukola.

Thierry gives team fishing

In 2013, Thierry won the Jukola with his French teammate Philippe Adamski.

Meeting...

The first time I met Thierry, was during the 1999 Nordic Competition in 1999 Trondheim. I met two young French juniors who were spectators at the relay because they had no third teammate to allow them to participate. These two "shy" Frenchmen were François Gonon and Thierry Gueorgiou. I was able to chat with Thierry and gave him a pack of Joensuu maps, not forgetting to add that Kalevan Rasti would like to see him in red and black!

Thierry can convert a 2D map into a 3D map

During the following summer and the summer of 2001, Thierry and I trained together in the region of Joensuu. From the beginning it was clear that Thierry was, in all respects, an exceptional reader of a map. He understood the relationship between map and ground both completely and quickly. I would say that Thierry is able to automatically transform a 2D map into a 3D image and vice versa. And I want to emphasise the word "automatically". It seemed like "the sky was the limit for him" and that's what actually happened soon...

I remember very well his disappointment after the WOC 2001 middle distance in Tampere, when, after a very clean race, he finished 18th and 2' 49" behind Pasi Ikonen. Later he admitted that, after the result of this race, he had to find a good reason to continue orienteering ... But history has shown that it was not wrong to carry on!

After Tampere, we continued our discussions and my conclusion was that Thierry was trying to read everything on his map, so as to be completely sure of his position. My opinion was that he should not concentrate on all the details, but that he had to identify on his map some remarkable points, obvious features that would allow him to maintain safe orienteering, but in a faster and straighter direction. These large elements would be, for the most part, contours lines, visible vegetation boundaries... but not point features....

After his first gold medal in Switzerland, in 2003, a sentence in his race analysis was significant. On a detailed and very short course, where he was much faster than the majority of competitors, he said (if I remember

In 2000, when Thierry joined the ranks of Kalevan Rasti, Börje Vartiainen (then coach of the club) became his first Finnish coach. He was to play an essential role in his career and help Thierry to make a decisive step forward technically.

Meet

the steep slope about twenty meters to the right and the control was obvious."

Afterwards, I always saw Thierry striving to complete his courses in a safe and fast way by concentrating on a few key obvious features. And at the same time, using his compass more and more effectively.

An orienteer who show lots of professionalism

There is no secret to Thierry's success. He was a professional orienteer who, in the early 2000s, raised the "art" of orienteering to a level that now all high-level elite orienteers strive to achieve. Thierry has spent a lot of time, during all these years, in all kinds of terrain, searching for reliable features to use to navigate fluidly and quickly, with the best route choice in all types of area. Before each WOC, he analyses the area to understand all the details: what is the green like for visibility and penetrability, state of the marshes, areas to be avoided, and all other information related to the forthcoming competition. This is simply what is called professionalism, which is now done by all high-level orienteers.

2017 saw the last race for Thierry in a World Championship. But one thing is certain: we will remember him as the "King of orienteering"! And if I were asked to describe Thierry in a sentence -
Börje Vartiainen "There's no secret to Thierry's success"

Börje Vartiainen

O'ringen 2013

Thierry at NAOM in Portugal, traditional first competition of the year

The sky is literally the limit for Thierry after his victory at the

Jukola 2014

By Heidi Arnesen and Pål Kittilsen

Heidi Arnesen and Pål Kittilsen, respectively silver medalist in the WOC 1991 relay in Czechoslovakia and bronze medalist at the World Military Championships in 1998, members of Norwegian clubs NTNUI and Freidig, both have the distinction of having participated in Pôle France training between January and June 1999. They give us their impressions of their experience within the group, training delivered by French coaches, and of course Thierry, who already had lots of potential, even as a junior!

Michel Gueorgiou kindly welcomed us to the January to June 1999 training, during our internships in Lyon. Like most Nordic orienteers, our expectations regarding the quality of the training and the French runners were rather "neutral". But we soon realised how wrong this was. We found a talented, ambitious and completely focused group of orienteers. During the whole training, the emphasis was on the technical side, to a level that we had never experienced before in Norway.

Thierry was immediately the one to beat, both in training and in competition. And even though he was still only a junior, his technical level was impressive. He almost never made mistakes, and it was very hard to better his times: only on one or two circuits per session. But he always had the best total time, primarily because he almost always had the best individual times. Back in Norway, we described how this group of French orienteers trained and how much they concentrated on technique. But nobody there believed us when we talked about their technical ability.

In the spring of 1999, the Nordic Open Championship (NOC) took place in our city of Trondheim. We were aware of the technical level of these young French, but we had the feeling that they did not realise it themselves. We were very eager to see them participate in these championships so that they received the "feedback" that they deserved. We contacted the organisers and arranged registrations and accommodation for the French runners. The next step was to convince FFCO to send two juniors: François Gonon and Thierry Gueorgiou. The FFCO provided the funds and it was north-wards for our two French friends! On ultra-specific Nordic terrain that they had never seen before, Thierry managed to take two medals and François a sixth place. They were not only sensational results, which would give them a huge boost in confidence, but it was also a nice confirmation of the technical level of all the other members of Pôle France. At that time, most Norwegians thought that at a junior level this was nothing extraordinary. They would have to

The Norwegian view of the junior Thierry Gueorgiou

Pôle France winter training weekend at Le Caylar, Larzac 1999 (from l. to r.) Rémi Gueorgiou, Damien Renard, Mathieu Brugat, Thierry, Pål Kittilsen, Chloé Manissolle, Heidi Arnesen, (front) François Gonon

The Pôle on the roadsof France in 1999

François Gonon and Thierry Gueorgiou

at the WOC 1999 in Trondheim, Norway

RESULTS OF NOC 1999

Long distance 1- Ivar Haugen NOR

1:10:01 2- Jonne Lakanen FIN

1:10:06 3- Thierry Gueorgiou FRA

1:11:40 6- François Gonon FRA

1:13:45

Middle distance 1- Timo Saarinen FIN

23.41 2- Thierry Gueorgiou FRA

23.51 3- Jonne Lakanen FRA

Thierry from A to Z

Thierry's partner, multiple world champion, including long distance in 2011 in Savoie, where Thierry also won gold. Annika grew up in Sweden in very different terrain from France. Winning multiple medals demonstrates her adaptability, which could be very useful for her life with Thierry.

A for ANNIKA

Thierry's biggest regret is that he never had the opportunity to run a major championship on Le Caylar in Larzac. From 1994, numerous elite training weekends on the map of "Bal des Rochers" played a key role in technical progress. For Thierry, "these are unique areas, and it would have been really special to organise a World Cup or a World Championships on them".

C for Caylar

Le bal des rochers, SHOCart, 1994

Thierry started orienteering at just two years old accompanied by his father. Indeed, it was his father's passion for orienteering coupled with his career as a teacher that resulted in a young Thierry picking up a map and trying out his father's innovative training exercises.

D for Deux (Two)

Paal and Heidi, Norwegian cousins, members of the Norwegian team, who came to Lyon in 1999, for their university studies. They were sea-son-tickets holders on the SNCF Lyon-Givors train line so they could join the Pôle France bus

K for KITTILSEN

(And to which we should add Portugal), the land of sun where all orienteering aficionados know that each year Thierry times himself on a course in the shape of a capital letter N (when most people are asleep or welcoming in the New Year).

E for Espagne (Spain)

Back in the 1990s at Grand Veymont (Isère), the Cadet group dunked a fully clothed Thierry in a cattle trough.

B for Bizutage

(Initiation)

Most people know this story! During the WOC 2009 World relay final leg in Hungary, Sweden's Martin Johansson and Thierry were racing together for the gold medal. Just after control 12, Martin was seriously injured and Thierry abandoned all thought of a medal to help him. He was joined by Norway's Anders Nordberg and Czech Michal Smola who also abandoned their runs to help. The three men eventually crossed the finish line together to a

standing ovation from the spectators and subsequently received the International Fair Play Award for their exemplary behaviour!

F for Fair Play

A city in Karelia, Finland and home of Finnish orienteering club Kalevan Rasti and two outstanding personalities: Urpo Väänänen (Director) and Börje Vartanen (Coach) who have made Thierry a friend and the "Paavo Nurmi" ("Flying Finn") of orienteering. And not forgetting

some excellent team victories at the Jukola and the TioMila, raising the profile of the club both in Finland and across Europe.

J for JOENSUU

The city of Inverness in Scotland has been event centre for two World Championships. In 1999, at the second World Senior championship in which Thierry participated, while still only a junior, he finished 24th in the short distance and 12th in the relay (a typical relay placing for the French squad in those days). Fast forward 16 years to 2015, where, three controls from the end of the Middle distance race, Thierry was just 3 seconds behind the leading time when an error in the map caused him to drop to 7th place. A little "angry", he won the long distance title three days later.

Thierry won the 2007 World Cup at Hovden. It was a memorable win because he dominated the opposition, scoring maximum points by winning all 8 of the races during the year. Thierry scored 700 points, the second place scored 381.

H for

HOVDEN

I for INVERNESS

En route to WOC 2005 in Japan, the French team (after a long journey) found themselves in a foreign airport where nothing made sense - a real culture shock. Having collected their hire car, they discovered that the GPS was only in Japanese! Thierry took over as co-pilot, tinkered with the GPS and delivered the team safely to their accommodation even without an orienteering map. A few days later, he again became world champion!

G for GPS

A "must" for any orienteer wishing to combine a holiday and orienteering is the Landes. For Thierry, back in 1984, it was a holiday, full of fun including a zip-line into a lake. He landed on an (unmapped) broken bottle resulting in a free trip by boat taxi to the nearest hospital to treat his right foot. He managed to get a 10 cm rusty nail in his left foot too, but not until the Austrian 5

L for Landes

A safe, fenced park in the town of Saint-Etienne where Thierry and his friends, then ten years old, could play safely amongst the flowers.

P for Perrotière

By the time of the 2005 World Cup in Italy, Thierry was at his peak physically and technically. But coach Jean-Paul Hosotte tells us how Thierry almost missed the start of his race. "I was just in front of the start area for the middle distance final. Thierry arrived

and began his start routines, he checked that I was there and set off for a short warm up jog four minutes before his start. I wasn't concerned because I knew from experience that he would get back one minute before his call-up. But then I realised that he was going too far and he began to disappear from sight! My blood ran cold! I quickly calculated his speed, the increasing distance and his start time. Was I mistaken? NO! I had to intervene so I ran as fast as I could to catch Thierry who was casually continuing his gentle warm-up. I slowed down and (without panicing) I said "Tero, you've got your start time wrong ... it is in two minutes." Without a single word, Thierry calmly went back to the start! He carried out his usual checks: watch, headband, compass, control description holder on the way ... and we arrived just in time for Thierry to walk straight into

H-3 ... Thirty minutes later, he crossed the finish line to win the bronze medal.

W for Warm-up

Thierry found himself at a loose end for most of the first week of the 2002 World University Championships in Sofia, Bulgaria (SOF) when his luggage made the trip via San Francisco in the United States (SFO)!

V for Valise (Suitcase) Swiss orienteer who has a course in

La Féclaz named after him; its ups and downs are supposed to represent the strength of his thighs. He

came third in the 1987 World Championships and made a great impression on Thierry.

As a teenager, his orienteering friends used the common nickname "Thier", or more unusually, "Cranberry legs"

because of the disproportionate length of his thin legs to his big knees, which was reminiscent of the stems of these shrubs. Later, the Finns gave him the nickname "Tero Kettunen" (the fox), one adopted by the public and which is still used today. Another nickname that did not last was the "King of Middle" as, after 9

years of an almost unpa-ralleled reign (2003-2011), Thierry suddenly decided to win at the long distance!

T for Tero

Thierry has always been a great experimenter, first at Pôle France with map reading, basketball, aqua-jogging, skiing, biking, etc. Then, later, injuries forced him to find solutions not yet recognised by the IOF such as fishing, Uno, pétanque, via ferrata (rock climbing assisted by fixed cables and ladders) or Alter-G (an Anti-Gravity treadmill).

X for Cross-training

or alternative workout

The concept of the Stéphanoise Method, used by Pôle France until 2000, and which Thierry perfected in "Full speed, no mistakes."

Z for

Zero mistakes Yari (13 years) and Sophie (9

years) - Thierry's nephew and niece, who have become experts in Catching Features (an electronic orienteering game) and in following the coloured spot with a tail of 1

Y for Yari

His brother, FISU World Champion 2000 and 2002, but more importantly the one that, despite the four year age gap, Thierry had in his sights from birth as the one to beat. In other words, a home target. A little unfair, because Rémi was the guinea pig for the coach to try out the new training methods, while Thierry just had to follow on...

R for Rémi

Eric Perrin was the first NOSE runner to qualify for the World Senior Championships in 1991 in Czechoslovakia - a great reason to go and support him while taking part in the 5 Days of Bohemia. Thierry, still a young H12, accomplished an incredible feat that was a sign of things to come: in the chasing start on the last day, Thierry caught up all the runners who had started in front of him by choosing a better route. After he had crossed the finish line, all his NOSE club mates carried him in triumph and tossed him in the air "in the Scandinavian way". This was his first international victory and perhaps the one that whet his appetite to come back for more.

Q for Qualification

Kent OLSSON became World Orienteering Champion in Gérardmer in 1987. His autographed photo (along with one of Jörgen Martensson) was stuck on the ceiling above Thierry's bed for several years. As far as we know, no proper scientific study has been carried out into the impact of these two Swedes on the sleep of children and teenagers! But the relationship is established between number of medals and 'full time' dreamers. Olsson and Martensson were also names given to test runs at La Féclaz in the 1990s.

O for (KENT) OLSSON

NATURE ORIENTATION SAINT-ETIENNE, Thierry's only French club. Its first President, Régis Antoine, had laid solid foundations -mapping and organising with rigorous pre-paration. Gradually, teachers, especially EPS, made sure that the club could fill a 50-seater bus both on Wednesday afternoons and at the weekend.

N for Nose

Throughout his career, Thierry has often heard the French national anthem. One of his favourite podium memories is the medal ceremony for the 2004 European Middle Distance Championships in Denmark, where the TADiens began to sing the Marseillaise a capella.

"This was by far

the most touching Marseillaise I've ever experienced," he says.

One of the unique NOSE and Pôle France technical training methods used for 15 years, and which helped to make Thierry the map reader that we know today.

S for Simulation

U for Urs Flühmann

Damien Renard "When Thierry began to get podium places, we realised that the French team had the potential to go far!

> Thierry started his high-level career with you. Can you tell us about your beginnings?

At the age of 17, after two years of studies at Font-Romeu high school, I joined the Pôle France group in Saint-Etienne in September 1997. The junior group had already formed around Thierry with François Gonon, Jean Baptiste Bourrin, Benoît Peyvel,

Matthieu Puech and Loïc Venon. I had to establish my place in the team and Thierry always supported me in doing that. He was already the leader at that time, even though everyone had a strong personality. Our dream was to become champions! I think that Thierry, unlike us, was really sure that he would get there some day. But we all wanted to be very successful in orienteering, and that's why we created "The Team". We organised mini courses on our free weekends and we even had our internal newspaper. I think that what made us successful was that we didn't take things too seriously. Apart from the workouts, it was a total blast!

On the other hand, in the forest, it was serious because we fought for our place in the group. When Thierry, then François, and then the others started to get results at an international level, we realised that it was possible. When you see that your friend is able to make a podium at a JWOC, you quickly realise that you are not far from Thierry as seen by...

> At that time, it seems that you were the only one able to stand up to Thierry in debates in the Pôle France minibus?

In this group of juniors we all had big mouths and despite being tired, in the Pôle minibus on the way back from events, everyone was really loud. In particular, we tended to go wild when we arrived on the Avenue de la Mintat at Saint-Etienne. We could get into heated debates, at the end of which it was often Thierry and I who could not let it go whatever the subject: selections, the federation, the rotten courses or Johnny Halliday ... I think it was more a form of competition that neither of us would give way to the other. Whoever lost was often a pretty bad loser and it grated on them for hours.

> In 2011, when Thierry, François and Philippe won the relay, Thierry immediately associated you with the victory although you had already left the French team. Did this touch you?

Of course it touched me! And it was typical of him. Thierry is a great team player and always thinks of others. This relay was our common project. After WOC 2005 in Japan, where the French relay team finished second, our goal was to win gold in the following years. But we had a lot of disappointments: 2006, 2007, 2008, 2009, 2010 ... Each time, one of us (or sometimes all three) made mistakes, or unpredictable external factors conspired against us. Philippe Adamski joined the team in 2008, which allowed the team to be more stable and more efficient. We were a tight squad, no matter which of the four of us was going to run. Of course, we all wanted to run and it was difficult to determine who should run, but we always managed to turn this to our advantage so that the relay team was the best possible. From these difficult years a very strong friendship was born which, I think, will remain strong despite the geographical distance between us.

Barbecue with friends after training on the Pilat Massif at Saint-Etienne, 2004 © The Team From l. to r. Damien Renard, Thierry Gueorgiou, Magalie Coupat and François Gonon at the Kindercup in Fontainebleau © The Team

Thierry as seen by his teammates

I have plenty of them and I hope there will be more! We've done so much together since the junior group. I especially remember when we were very young and we were participating in our first TioMila. It was in 1999. We were like children, amazed by everything that we saw around us. The scale of this race amazed us. We each had the chance to run for a

Scandinavian club (Thierry already with Kalevan Rasti and me with OK Denseln). This excitement and admiration will remain forever in my memory. Since then, we have each won the TioMila and the Jukola with our respective clubs (always with Kalevan Rasti for Thierry, and Kristiansand OK for me) but each time I remember that day in 1999. We've come a long way since then. Today, it's almost impossible to talk to Thierry at the TioMila as everybody wants to talk with him.

I could also tell you about our endless basketball games, in Allée Chantegrillet in Saint-Etienne, but I will keep that for another time.

> What is the main thing that you will remember about Thierry?

Thierry is an extremely committed and persistent person, who will not let go until he has achieved his goal. And this is his greatest strength. It is this incredible desire and this extraordinary capability to believe in his own ability that has allowed him to climb onto the highest steps of the podiums. I do not think that he has any doubts about his ability to succeed. At the same time, and it's almost paradoxical, he cares a lot about others. His words to me at the WOC 2011 relay are a very good example. I don't see our friendship stopping, so I find it difficult to say what I will remember. I just wish Thierry all the best for his retirement from high-level competition.

Jean-Baptiste Bourrin "Thierry has marked orientee-ring forever!"

> It seems that Thierry is your "mentor"? Did he give you advice on how to perform?

Mentor maybe but liar certainly! I followed all his advice to the letter and I never performed like him....? But seriously, Thierry has towed a whole generation in his wake. I'm referring to the generation of France 98, with François Gonon, Damien Renard, Benoit Peyvel, Loïc Venon, Matthieu Puech, Pauline Filet, Chloé Manissolle, Magali and Estelle Tinchant and Laëtitia Piaulat.

not been limited to the last century as he continues to take our current top young athletes under his wing. This is generous especially as, for some, it's not the first priority of a top athlete. He has brought international recognition for France!

> Do you have a special memory or an anecdote to share?

You know, at my old age (the same as Tero by the way) memories are a bit faded, maybe even wrong ... I had finished second in a French long distance championship in the Ardennes, just a few seconds behind the man. This championship was a little Loire derby! (I told you that my memories were fading ...). On that occasion, OE42 were staying in the same place as NOSE and to annoy me Tero rubbed in every second that separated me from first place by posting them along the way to my room. I was actually very happy with my unexpected second place! And I could tell you about the few times that I managed to beat the animal ... but I also have to tell you that you can count them on the fingers of one hand (not counting training of course, otherwise it takes more than one hand...).

> What will you remember most about Thierry?

And s*** that's it, (sob..) ... Don't worry readers, he's not dead ... you fooled me with your question! Well, seeing that he's not dead, it's necessary to remove two or three qualities that I ascribed to him or he will get a big head...that's a fault isn't it?

Well if he has one, it is probably that he cannot help but take everything he does seriously. It's like the desire to win at any price in any game. Is this a fault? To get the same results as he does in orientee-ring in other games, he trains in secret beforehand to ensure that he beats us. And that is his real secret: work when no one is looking and then work some more! I wish you as good a time in retirement as you have had in your career!

Thierry (left) and Damien (right) at the TioMila, 1999 © The Team Training session for WOC 2003 in Italy with "Friend Pastos" (aka JB Bourrin)

Nationale 2004 in Chamrousse, Thierry again first ahead of his friends Damien

Thierry as seen by...

Frédéric Tranchand "Thierry helped me a lot in my transition to the top level"

> At WOC in Italy in 2014, you won the bronze in the relay with Thierry and François Gonon. The names of the French orienteers to have won a medal with Thierry can be counted on the fingers of one hand. Are you happy to be able to write your name on this list?

It was a dream to be able to run a world championship relay in the same team as Thierry and François! The previous year, I had already had the opportunity to run with Thierry and Philippe Adamski, "the dream team"! However, a big mistake at the beginning of my relay had hampered the team's chances. Nevertheless, this enormous disappointment served as a good lesson for the sequel! In 2014, I was really satisfied, even relieved, to have a good run on the first leg. And getting on the podium with Thierry and François is, of course, a very wonderful memory!

> Even then Thierry had begun to be part of the "old guard" and you the "new kids". Was he like your older brother?

In fact, when I started as a senior in 2009, Alain Berger (the coach of the French team at that time) decided who slept in which room during the competitions. Being the youngest, I found myself on several occasions in the same room as Thierry. It may seem trivial, but it helped me enormously in learning about the elite level in general. His professionalism and investment of time to prepare for each competition in the smallest detail is impressive and exemplary! Moreover, by having an older 'brother', the objective has always been to catch up with him or even to do better than him. In this sense too, I can consider Thierry as a big brother. That said, given the investment and intensity that Thierry puts into each training or competition, you really have to fight to try to beat him at any time!

> Do you have a special memory or an anecdote to share?

Many memories come to mind, but I remember one particular day. It was during a French Gendarmerie championship, which took place at a Gendarmerie school. During the prize-giving ceremony, we were in military uniform.

Thierry in his Gendarmerie uniform, and it was especially funny to see that all the students were a little stressed when greeting him, not because they knew who he was, but because of his rank (lieu-tenant cadet).

> What thing about Thierry will you remember?

His professionalism, his 100% commitment to succeed, his determination, his quest for efficiency, his passion for orienteering and sport in general, his generosity and his ability to step back and take a perspective on his activity and performance.

Vincent Coupat "Thierry has been a driving force for the French team"

> Was Thierry an example for you?

I think that most of the athletes who have met Thierry have found him a role model. I was present in 2003, at his first world championship in Switzerland, and it was undoubtedly this moment and Thierry himself who attracted me to the high level. Later, I trained with him and it's only natural that he has become a model in all the facets of high-level sport and orienteering. Beyond technique and training, he is at the forefront in dietetics and psychology for example, and always very professional in all his actions. In short, for me, he represents from all sides the best of a high-level athlete.

> What do you get from being a member of the French team?

Thierry was a driving force for the French team. The one to learn from, the one to beat and the one who drove us to be better. I regularly trained with him, shadowed him on sessions to watch him and tried to challenge him (losing most of the time, but what a satisfaction it was to beat him!). He is also the one who prepared most rigorously for competitions and helped the French team to make the right choices during the preparations (choice of maps, training...). Finally, I am very proud to have been with him all these years and I think that we still do not appreciate how lucky we have been to have the best orienteer with us.

> Do you have a special memory or an anecdote to share?

A race analysis after a high level weekend in Fontainebleau. I was in my last year in H20 and after the long distance race on Sunday which hadn't been too good. I remember taking some poor routes and debriefing with him and telling him what I did (badly), such as not using the relief and focusing on the rocks. At the end, after 30 minutes of discussion, I had really progressed and understood things.

> What thing about Thierry you will remember?

Thierry, François and Frédéric at WOC 2014

Tero and Fredo in 2015 during a personal training course in Alicante (Spain)

The France group in 2010, after a caving trip during WOC 2011

only in competitions but also in each training session. Most of us, at some point, crack completely on a control or on a complete exercise because one is tired, one thinks of something else, ... Thierry always surprised me because it was very rare for him to make this type of error. He has the ability to stay focused and his technique is so well embedded that the difference between an average and a good performance for him is very small (and his average level is very high). He is also a runner who can devastate the leading time of a race or a split time to a control. We knew that if it was won in 35 minutes, Thierry could do 34 and then he would do 33! He could always surprise us!

Lucas Basset "With Thierry, even in a fun competition, we didn't start without preparation"

> You have just started your move to the highest level with some great victories already. Does a career like his make you dream?

Achieving such a high level of performance over such a long period of time, that makes you dream! But I don't delude myself, a career like his, that's not going to happen to me. That's because today I am not able to dominate as he has over so many years (especially between 2003 and 2011), and also because I'm pretty sure I will stop before getting to 38 years old. Overall, I can say that I don't aspire at all to a career like Thierry's, because that would be beyond my wildest dreams; I would content myself with much less! On the other hand, Thierry has made me dream since the first WOC I followed on the Internet, the one in Sweden in 2004. I can't count the interviews I have read about him, his analyses of races, his articles at the time on his website. I'm a great orienteering fan; no doubt that's partly thanks to him!

> It seems that you do not have the same vision of high-level orienteering and that your approach to training for competitions is different.

Thierry is unique in his approach to competition. He is a 100% professional. Even today, for his 18th senior world championship (if I am right), he is willing to put everything in place to win. He cannot be satisfied with second place, that is because it is difficult to envisage being anything but on top when you have already won everything. Finally, it must be a rather uncomfortable position to be in since there is only one "good" exit to the competition: a win. I'm not going to say that I don't want to win 13 world championship titles, but that would worry me a bit. The big difference between us, I think, is how we train and prepare. Thierry

will link together an incalculable number of orienteering training sessions. Almost every day he trains in a specific way, a training camp where I love to orienteer three times a day, I prefer not train "every day". One or two sessions a week are enough for me, if I do too much then I get too tired so I prefer to keep sharp for key sessions. I also hardly ever plan my sessions myself, in fact, almost never. So, if you look at the number of sessions done, nobody gets close to Tero. In fact, he is probably the world benchmark in terms of training! Next, Thierry focuses his preparations for championships on very detailed analysis of the event bulletins, aerial photos, and test courses. He needs to know everything and to have anticipated everything to feel ready. I hate this type of preparation. I prefer to remain flexible, so as not to have bad surprises if the reality isn't what I had imagined. Yet, of course, I'm inspired by Thierry! His technical ability, his experience and his experience of high level make him an example to everybody. And his professionalism rubs off on all those who spend time with him. A few years ago, I did not want to hear about diet, etc. I was a bit of a dilettante. In short: zero professionalism! I think I have changed a lot, and it's the rigour of the French team, with the example of Thierry, which has pushed me to do it, to become more serious in my preparation.

> Do you have a special memory or an anecdote to share?

A special memory is the week we spent together in La Plagne in 2011 for the Stars of Sport. Thierry had chosen me as the hopeful that he sponsored and it was one of the best weeks of my life: six days at the Club Med de la Plagne among great French sports stars (Laurent Blanc, Youri Djorkaeff, Nikola Karabatic, Marie-Jo Pécé, Christophe Lemaître and so on). At the start, we did not know what we were doing there! But we quickly found our place and we had a lot of fun. There are two particular things that I remember from that week:

The Raid of the Stars: which we won hands down. On the day before, Thierry and I went to look at the route and decide the strategy that we would adopt while the others did nothing. Even though the competition was for fun, we couldn't start without preparation. That best sums up Thierry.

A classic moment on the last evening: Yannick Noah invited us both on stage to sing with him. Watching Thierry accompanied by Yannick Noah, Tony Estanguet and Abdelatif Benazzi labouring through Chuck Berry's Johnny B Goode was priceless!

> What thing about Thierry will you remember ?

He is not dead yet so I hope to spend some more time with him, even
2014 European Champions

Thierry as seen by...

Michel Gueorgiou (1994-2004) "If he had been Nordic or Swiss, the media would have recognised Thierry as they do a multi-ple Olympic champion!"

> What role did FFCO play in Thierry's career?

In the late 1980s, FFCO began to take an interest in elite training, creating, thanks to a group of effective volunteers, in addition to the junior group, a group of cadets, in which Thierry participated enthusiastically. An important step change came in 1994 with the appointment of Jean-Luc Toussaint to become the National Technical Director of the Federation. A former high-level athlete, he had experienced the great era of National Technical Director Robert Bobin at the French Athletics Federation. It should not be forgotten that before him, all the French orienteering team coaches were volunteers and also ... very good mini-bus drivers, delivery specialists both in Scandinavia and in Eastern Europe, and excellent runners even with legs completely exhausted after two days of driving! Thierry,

fortunately, did not experience this heroic period. It was also Jean-Luc Toussaint who obtained the Ministry of Sports funding necessary for the creation of Pôle France. This allowed me to apply, with much improved resources, the training that we had previously developed in our club.

> You are surely Thierry's most "special" coach. How did you plan and follow your son's career?

After our exams to become EPS teachers, Thierry's mother Marie-Christine and I attended the training organised by the French Athletics Federation for their coaches. Javelin throwing particularly interested me and, because of the results of my throwers, the javelin national coach had asked me to join him.

But there was no question of moving away from the family, Thierry and Rémi absolutely needed me to referee their never-ending competitions of

"who-will-be-first-to-touch-that-tree-over-there", particularly as I planned the handicaps so that the results were always uncertain. We can, therefore, clearly say that Thierry benefited (or suffered) from an early culture of competition.

Then, Thierry followed his elder brother, first at NOSE, then at Pôle France. It was in these structures that he became accustomed to never running without having a "map in the head", practising what I first called simulation and, later, the Stéphanoise method. This method uniquely gave a place to night training sessions: at least once a week throughout the year and even more in winter. Pôle France was launched with a night simulation session in the gym where the maps were read with headlamps. The swarm of fireflies created by the headlamps impressed the officials present.

Both with Thierry and others, I have never been a coach-guru who gives a very strict training plan. My way was to prepare a multitude of maps for group sessions in which everyone had their own map to read while running. Thierry knew very early, to take the best from all the sessions

> Did you have a real coach-athlete relationship or more of a father-son relationship?

Whether in training or in competition, I never made a difference between my sons and the others. As training was almost every day, the father-son relationship certainly suffered ... especially when results were delayed or injuries occurred.

As a father, it would have been more normal to be able to show more empathy towards him and his brother, but that was the price to pay for the training group keeping its momentum. With hindsight, we can look back and say that the relationship with my sons would have been better if I had not been their coach. Especially when their mum was no longer there to grease the wheels.

> You were more demanding with Thierry than the others?

No, but Thierry was part of the group of runners that I knew intimately. They all shared the same goals and the same tiredness associated with training loads. They set the benchmarks for what I had in mind was necessary to reach the top international level.

For any given map and terrain, I could almost predict if Thierry would do well or not. The more detailed the terrain and the less runnable, the more his map reading favoured him compared to his training partners. It's also necessary to remember the level of French clubs in the 1980s -to motivate the NOSE "troops" during competitions, I instituted a special award for all NOSE Gaulois who succeeded in beating a Viking.

> In 2004, Jean-Paul Hosotte succeeded you. Did you have any concerns in seeing your son coached by someone else?

Not at all, because we transitioned gradually during the spring coaching sessions in 2004. Jean-Paul Hosotte was an expert in high level sport and it was he who was most important

during international competitions. In addition, Thierry had his career well in hand since he was already at Kalevan Rasti.

> What do you think about Thierry's career?

Given his record, if he had been Nordic or Swiss, he would have been recognised by the media at a level equivalent to that of a multiple Olympic champion. The quality of his map reading and his preparations for the big competitions are exemplary. He has also in a way revolutionised the middle-distance event. Before him, victory went to the runner who made the fewest errors. Since 2003, with few exceptions (often due to mapping problems), he has managed a lot of error-free races; what he calls "full speed-no mistakes".

His career also shows what admiration of champions by a little boy of 8 (at WOC 1987 in Gérardmer) can bring to life. I know that he became a "full-time dreamer" from this event!

But his dream is far from

Thierry as seen by his coaches

Olivier COUPAT (2000 - 2004) "His greatest quality was that he hated being beaten." > At what point in his sporting career did you coach Thierry?

I cannot pretend to say that I coached Thierry in the years that he was at Pôle France. I had Thierry as an athlete at Pôle France in Saint-Etienne. Thierry was already a very self-contained athlete in all areas of training (planning, recovery, diet ...); he had already mastered all the logistics of training for an endurance sport like orienteering. My approach was more to ensure that he had the best arrangements, the best possible training conditions in and around Saint Etienne and also to ensure that he didn't make any training mistakes, a sort of "security blanket". Also to bring novelty, changes in training to break the routine and give him the motivation needed to keep progressing.

> What were the main qualities and faults of Thierry?

The main qualities at the time: He didn't like being beaten, he hated it. He has always been autonomous in his training and his athletic career. Curious, he learned about training methods in other countries, and adapted them to suit him. He was already very professional, left nothing to chance and his life in general was organised towards performance. Thierry was always full of ideas, he brought back new ideas from his travels or training camps with his Finnish club or other places around the globe ... then I tried to put in place his ideas, his new contributions, to make it work for the Pôle athletes group.

Faults: he had not yet developed sufficient muscle strength both in general and more particularly in his lower limbs. He was a very bad loser whatever the situation, informal collective activities at the end of training or warm-up, even board games. Sometimes this led to tension within the group. His racing speed was not very high, especially in the finish lane.

> What did you want to bring him in your role as coach?

Undeniably, I think it was strength training that was my main contribution to Thierry during the years in Pôle France. It was not in the culture of high-level orienteering to do bodybuilding. In fact, it was more physical preparation than real bodybuilding at the start (it was Alain Berger who introduced real bodybuilding using bars with weights). It was more the core strength, drills, proprioception and support work, all during very specific gymnasium sessions.

> For you, what is Thierry's main character trait that sets him apart from others?

Character trait: professionalism pushed to the extreme. He considered high level sport as a way of life demanding very great rigour and attention to detail. To me, he's one of the greatest French champions who have never received the recognition he deserves due to the lack of media coverage of our sport.

What differentiates him from others is his mental strength in competition, his high level of analytical capability and the evolution of his orienteering technique throughout his career. What has impressed me the most is his last World Championship title this year. The pressure to finish his career, to finish at the top, all that has amazed me. Not many great champions are successful. The difference

Jean-Paul Hosotte (2004-2005) "And Tero gets angry, a rare occurrence....."

> Do you have a memory or an anecdote to share?

I'd like to go back to the WOC 2004 in Sweden and the pre-WOC training camp. We were on a lovely rock slab picnicing between two training sessions, and Thierry was glued to his Smartphone to watch the Athens Olympics. That's normal these days but 12 years ago it was avant-garde. Suddenly, Thierry announced that Julien Absalon was the cross-country mountain bike Olympic champion. It was a magnificent moment when we joined together with other sports (that take place in the countryside) to celebrate his performance.

And then there was the WOC itself. It's Friday the 17 September 2004, eve of the middle distance final. We were going training in Tillingarna with the French team. We asked those who already been

there: "you remember where we are going?" Answer: "Yes! We drive about 20 km and then turn left after a red farm ... " And Tero gets angry, a rare occurrence ... he sits down in the car as the navigator to find the entrance to the track and the path to the beginning of the planned training. His anger soothed, the training goes smoothly and the next day he is world champion. When I think about it, this was quite a paradoxical situation for high level orienteers and it made me smile...but the desire to win is not at all a matter of fun, and for this, complete respect!

Alain Berger (2009-2011) "Thierry's career is a wonderful example for young athletes"

> **While you were still an athlete, you raced against Thierry. What memories do you have of this young competitor?**

In 1999, while participating in my last world championships, Thierry (still a junior) took part in his first WOC. It was at this time that we began to have some exchanges. A little later, at a national at Semnoz, I remember that we discussed "surfing on the hillsides". Tero, always interested, was very curious and came to find out more.

> At what point of his sporting career did you coach Thierry?

He had already had an incredible amount of success and I was told, not by him directly, that he was asking questions about the future. I looked after the team from 2009 to 2011. There was the episode of the wasp in 2008. In 2009, he rescued the injured Swede during the WOC relay. All this meant that getting the relay medal that he wanted was delayed and so, when it was achieved, it was very intensely emotional. I think that Thierry, after all his individual successes, also wanted success with his teammates, François Gonon and Philippe Adamski, and later Frédéric Tranchand and he shared a lot with them.

> What were the main qualities and faults of Thierry?

His quest for technical perfection got him to the level he is at today. But at the same time, it is this that made him neglect long distance for a large part of his career, suggesting that had the view that long distance was not sufficiently technically challenging.

So it was not his priority, and if it had been then he may have won more medals! I didn't discuss it with him and I would be curious to hear his reac-

Thierry as seen by...

> What did you want to bring him in your role as coach?

I spent time getting him to appreciate the long distance; he had by then, the necessary maturity and the success followed. We also worked on the relay. We had memorable team

meetings in which we reviewed all possible race situations, but also where painful decisions had to be made, and through this process the team was built. An anecdote from the preparation for WOC 2011: we had devoured controls, done multiple very intensive courses in similar areas to the Revard - in the Jura, in the Vercors and in Slovenia, we were ready! We added a caving trip to the programme of the last training camp at Lescheraines, and Thierry was the happiest person in the group, covered with mud from head to toe. During the camp, we also wanted to push the athletes to the limit of their comfort zone by going on a surprise activity -this was a horseback ride. And there, there was a bit of hesitation; Thierry who works to have everything under control, had to depend on an animal that he was not in full control of, but it went well and it was an key experience.

> How did coaching work with him? What was your coach-athlete relationship?

It is hard to help to improve Thierry's technical skills. The relationship I had with him was that of an enthusiast and a perfectionist who respect each other's work. During the three years that I coached the team, I was not coaching Thierry, but the team. I wanted to offer a structure and content that was adapted to the best, it was not possible for everyone to follow it but I believe that Thierry probably appreciated this structured approach.

> What are your views on Thierry's career?

Thierry's career is a magnificent example for young athletes who can see that, with commitment and passion, success can be achieved. And that along this road one has both hard and wonderful experiences that altogether are very enriching.

> His career was long. What mark will he leave in the orienteering world?

He has had a lot of success but he has left his trademark "full speed, no mistakes". Orienteering is not a media sport, he has not won millions but he has left his mark on his sport in the same way as Federer has with tennis.

> Thierry has announced the end of his career and will be coach of the Swedish team at the start of the next season. Is it a role in which he will be effective?

Yes, he will be good with committed and passionate athletes, the others will probably be a bit more concerned. He will definitely enjoy this role and the Swedish team will get better! He will live, through the athletes, the emotions that he has experienced himself. He will lose patience during the interminable "team leader meetings" or in quarantine before the starts, but that's part of the job!

> In a few words, how would you define Thierry?

Kenneth BUSH (2011-2013) "Thierry's potential has no limits".

> When did you want to recruit Thierry?

The first time I met Thierry was in 2008. I was trying to get him to sign for Halden SK, who I coached at that time. Thierry was already the best athlete in the world and as a coach, the opportunity to work with the elite is always interesting! Unfortunately, this time, Thierry refused to change and remained loyal to Kalevan Rasti in an attempt to win 10mila. Kalevan succeeded (and many times afterwards), and with this example Thierry showed me that when he defined a goal, he did not give up until he had obtained it. Then, in 2011, I found myself as the coach of the French team, so Thierry did not escape me. That year he won WOC medals, so my expectations were enormous for the future. As his results were already impressive, I knew that my only goal was to determine what his motivations were, and to encourage them. I also wanted to use Thierry to help to lead and motivate the rest of the French team. And of course, as a personal goal, I was very interested in his own experiences and his training methods.

> How did coaching work with him? What was your relationship coach-athlete?

Thierry's potential has no limits, as with many of the top athletes that I meet. However, the investment (which is huge) to become the best in the world is very different from the motivation to stay there, and that's what I saw in Thierry. When I trained the French team, Thierry suffered some injuries, and perhaps realised that his body had limits. I think that he needed time to adapt to this, which he did and then went on to become the best athlete in the world in 2013.

> What do you remember about Thierry?

The first time I set foot in Thierry's apartment, I was impressed by the enormous number of cushions to strengthen his ankle. I thought at that moment that he was a passionate man, even obsessed by his passion!

Charly Boichut (2014-2017) "During training sessions, when the group was still preparing to attack control A, Thierry was already considering how to approach control C or D!"

> For you, what is the main character trait of Thierry, which differentiates him from others?

His attention to detail! With Thierry, you can be sure that everything is taken into account. Orienteering issues are only some of the factors related to performance that he takes into account when taking decisions/actions. To give you a concrete example, quite often during training sessions, while the group is just preparing to attack control A, Thierry is already considering how to approach control C or D.

So, planning training camps to meet the level of his expectations is a permanent challenge, sometimes difficult to satisfy. But it's an incredible catalyst in the progress of the group!

> What is Thierry's particular skill in competition?

That's the thing, he doesn't have one. Better than anyone, he wants to do in a competition what he's done in training, and to repeat in training what he will have to do in competition.

> What will you remember of his career?

A career that could not be more rich and accomplished, with all that it encompasses: exploits, great duels, surreal events, domination, some failures, and an

Medals won by Thierry at World Championships

(gold, silver, bronze)

23 458

Interviews that Thierry has done throughout his career

Number of hours of training recorded during one week in Alicante

37.5 7

litres (of water!) that Thierry drank every day at the 2005 World Championships in Japan
8

Pairs of shoes used every year by Thierry
100

Finish position in 1996 JWOC middle distance
38

Number of countries in which Thierry has participated in competition
20

years between his first world championships (1997) and his last (2017)

18

compasses broken by Thierry

1.93

Thierry's height

257

training days completed

by Thierry in 2011

3

Finnish clubs (Kalevan Rasti, Delta, Paimion Rasti) interested in trying

to recruit Thierry in 2000

172

days spent training in Alicante (Spain)

in 1997

3.5

His average mark in German at college

(out of 20 ...)

2'38"

the margin by which Thierry won his

first World Championship title

25 minutes

the duration of Thierry's daily nap!

4 933

Followers of Thierry on Twitter

Thierry in numbers

Thierry at the France Bleu microphone at WOC 2011

Traditional winter training in Alicante

Thierry tells us about eight milestone dates in his life ...

8 memorable events

8 memorable events

By Thierry Gueorgiou

July 14, 1998 My first medal (silver) at the Junior World Championships organised at Reims in France. This was, by far, the most significant period of my life. Six days before, my mum closed her eyes for the last time, after an aggressive cancer. Running at the championship was not the first thing on my mind, but she would not have wanted me to be anywhere else that day. I kept thinking of the Titanic orchestra, which continued to play as the ship sank after hitting an iceberg. After some poor performances at the previous JWOCs, I was called "mentally weak," but this period of my life definitely toughened me up.

August 8, 2003 My first World Championship title at Triin in the Swiss Alps. It's not hard to remember this date because it clearly marks a "before" and an "after" in my sporting life. After that, even if I felt the same, others would see me in a different light and I had to learn to live with that pressure.

October 2005 FFCO signs Norwegian Petter Thoresen, multiple world champion and my childhood idol, as coach of the French team. It's a dream come true. After my father, who taught me the basics and guided me to the title of world champion, Petter is the coach who has been most important to me. He allowed François Gonon, Damien Renard and I to follow our destinies and to build memories for life.

September, 1995 Launch of the French Pôle Orienteering project at Saint-Etienne. The Federation offered us the opportunity to catch up with the other major nations by creating a structure focused on performance - a small group, supervised by passionate and competent people, including athletes and medics, all with one obsession: excellence pushed to the extreme, five days a week, three weekends a month and hundreds of kilometres travelled to reach the best French terrain! But what I remember above all is this extraordinary personal and sports adventure.

Finish of the JWOC 1998 long distance

Pôle France weekend at Sisteron, 2000

First world title

Petter Thoresen, French team coach

My first long distance world championship title, won in an indescribable atmosphere on the Féclaz plateau. As soon as I crossed the line, I learned that my Swedish companion, Annika, was also a gold medalist. That morning she had uttered the words "I love you" for the first time. In short, it was a dream day ... except that she won her race by 4' 28 ", and I won mine by 4' 27"! I am still regularly reminded about that one second...

July 12, 2014 We didn't know it at the time, but this was to be my long-time team-mate and friend forever, François Gonon's last race in the French team. We won the bronze medal in the relay with Frédéric Tranchand. François was then offered an opportunity that he could not refuse: to coach the Swiss team. A page turns, the excellent atmosphere in the French team continues, but I lose one of my benchmarks, and nothing will ever be the same.

July 6, 2017 My last individual race in a World Championship: my middle distance in Estonia. Without doing anything out of the ordinary, because I always tried to stream-line my preparation and stay in the present moment, I had a huge desire to fully savour this day. That was the case, and I left through the front door!

July 25, 2017 Probably the most significant event of my life - the arrival of Annika and my first child, and the beginning of a, just as exciting, new life!

Thierry, François and Fredo win bronze at WOC 2014

Thierry at the finish at

Leon and his dad taking a nap at the water's edge

Having met in France in 2011, Annika Billstam and Thierry Gueorgiou are now living together in Annika's home country of Sweden. She is also a high-level orienteer and multiple World Championship medalist (3 gold medals, 3 silver and 8 bronze), Annika tells us about the life of a champion couple!

> When and where did you meet Thierry? What was he like when you first met him?

Thierry and I met during the preparations for WOC in France at the beginning of 2011. Of course I already knew who he was, but it was the first time that we spent time together and we got to know each other more closely. I especially remember when he joined one of the Swedish team training sessions and he shadowed me as a part of the training. Of course I got lost but, in my defence, the terrain at WOC 2011 was quite hard for most of the participants...

I also remember that I was impressed by his openness. He paid a lot attention to all the national teams and runners, putting energy and effort into sharing his knowledge with them in their

Annika Billstam

> It's more than 5 years since Thierry settled in Sweden. How is his Swedish? You speak French. So which language do you speak at home?

As Thierry is a professional orienteer and travels a lot he doesn't need to speak much Swedish in his daily life. As a result, he understands Swedish well but still speaks in English. As a couple, we speak English, as it's the language in which we both express ourselves best. But now that we have a baby, the other's mother tongue.

> We know Thierry in the forest, but what is he like at home?

I would say he's the same person in the forest as he is at home. His characteristics are open mindedness, humbleness, eager-ness, passion and dedication to the moment.

And he's generous as a person.

> You are also a high level orienteer, and you have an impressive collection of medals.

What is the everyday life of a couple of champions like? Is it a life "in the fast lane"?

Of course we have busy days but we also slow down now and then to recharge our batteries. Luckily, we have a similar tempo

Annika Billstam "The high level brought us together and allowed us to understand each other"

Annika ended her career at WOC 2015 with a gold medal in the middle distance.

« Thierry is a very generous person »

tand each other and we know when and how to support each other, if needed.

> What with training, the training camps, competitions ... do you have time to see each other? Is there a line between your professional and personal life?

Since I stopped my international elite career we see less of each other because of all the travelling which international orienteering demands. When Thierry is at home we try to plan things so that I can take part in many of his training sessions but also have time for other things that we like to do. It's important to have more than one thing in life which brings joy!

> Apart from orienteering, what other activities do you like to practise (together or separately)?

We do a lot of things together like cooking, biking, cross-country skiing and ice skating in winter, travelling, watching movies and meeting up with friends and family. The list goes on and on.

> Who cooks at home? And is the menu Swedish or French?

When Thierry is at home he cooks most of the meals. And besides, he loves to cook. It's almost his second passion after orienteering! But we both like cooking and try out a lot of new recipes together as well. I wouldn't say that the menu is either Swedish or French, because it depends on our desires at the time. For example, Thierry's favourite dish at the moment is the "Poké bowl", with sashimi and kimchi, all served with sesame sauce. It's a Hawaiian-inspired recipe, and a regular at week-ends when we're at home. But we don't forget to eat properly because good nutrition is essential in the life of a professional athlete.

> During big competitions, Thierry appears to concentrate very hard. Is this, in your view, what allows him to succeed?

I believe that one of his strongest capacities is his capability to focus when it's needed. He knows which are the crucial moments of a race. It has become a habit, both at the world championships

and other competitions. The only difference between, for example, a national competition and a world championship is the time and effort he puts into his preparation.

> When you follow Thierry's races, are you calm or stressed?

I'm usually calm. He's so technically skilled and it's seldom that he makes mistakes. But the margins among top male orienteers today are very small and it has been a long time since a clean race automatically guaranteed a top position. Today it's much more exciting to follow.

> What is your best memory (sports or personal) with Thierry so far?

I would say, without doubt, that it was at WOC 2011 when we both won the long distance title in La Feclaz. It was an extraordinary moment. It was my first WOC gold medal and the first gold medal in long distance for Thierry. Our relationship was just starting. We were over-joyed. Those feelings, together with Thierry's first gold on home ground with a magical atmosphere in the arena, made this an unforgettable moment and really special to us.

> If you had to choose a single word to represent Thierry, it would be which one?

« WOC 2011 in France will probably be our

best memory! »

Annika and Thierry after their respective long distance victories at WOC 2011

Whether they have all the comforts of a fully equipped

kitchen or just a simple stove, Annika and Thierry

like to enjoy the best recipes from Top Chef!

WOC (World Championships)

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An impressive track record!

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WCup (World Cup)

JWOC (Junior World Orienteering Championships)

The World Games

EYOC (European Youth Orienteering Championships)

WUOC (World University Orienteering Championships)

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Jukola

In World Cup races Thierry has won 29 Gold, 12 Silver and 9 Bronze medals

EOC (European Orienteering Championships)

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ETOC (European Trail Orienteering Championships)

Kent Olsson, 1987 world champion

1988, his first French championship

2003, first gold medal

1979

Thierry was born on March 30 in Saint-Etienne. At the age of 4, he had already completed his first orienteering courses

with his parents Marie-Christine and Michel, and his older brother Rémi.

1987

Thierry is a keen spectator at the first

World Championship held in France, at Gérardmer. Having seen the victory of the Sweden's Kent Olsson, he dreams of becoming world champion!

1988

Thierry takes part in his first French

Championship, in H12. He finishes 3rd.

1997

Aged 18, Thierry makes his international debut representing France at the World Championships in Norway. He finished

in 50th place in the short distance.

2000

At Loge des Gardes (Auvergne), Thierry wins three of his five World University Champions titles.

2003

Thierry wins his first World

Championships gold medal, in Switzerland, in the middle distance. He finishes in front of Norwegians Bjørnar Valstad and Øystein Kristiansen, and becomes the first orienteering World

Champion in French history.

2004

With his Finnish club Kalevan Rasti, who

he signed for in 2000, Thierry wins the world's biggest relay, the Jukola, in Finland. He is the first non-Scandinavian to run the last leg of the Jukola and win.

Four other victories follow in 2005, 2007, 2013 and 2014, often with a decisive last leg run from Thierry.

2005

Passionate about nature, Thierry receives his Masters in Ecology and Ethology from the University of Saint-Etienne, before starting his full-time sporting career.

2006

By winning all the races in the finals of the World Cup in Auvergne, Thierry wins his first World Cup overall classification. He will remain unbeaten in international competitions on French soil.

2007

In Croatia, Thierry obtains the first of his five World Military Champion titles

2009

In the lead on the last leg of the relay World Championships in Hungary, Thierry and his Czech and Norwegian colleagues stop their race to help an injured Swedish runner. Their actions win them the international fair play award.

2010

With his Finnish club, Thierry wins his first TioMila in Sweden (the other great Scandinavian relay). Three more victories follow in 2011, 2013 and 2014.

2011

In an electric atmosphere, Thierry and his French teammates win the World Championships relay in France. With his first long distance race win a few days earlier, he became the first male orienteer in history to have won all the distances at a World Championship.

2012

On 29 November, Thierry left France to settle in Uppsala, Sweden just 60 kilometres north of Stockholm.

2013

Thierry wins the O'ringen - the last major title to elude him. Two further victories follow in 2014 and 2016.

2017

Thierry completed his last season as a high level athlete by winning the middle distance gold medal at the World Championship in Estonia on 6 July before becoming coach of the Swedish team.

The 4 musketeers. FISU world relay champions: Damien Renard, Rémi Gueorgiou, François Gonon,

Thierry Gueorgiou

Anders Nordberg, Thierry Gueorgiou and Michal Smola receiving congratulations from IOF Victory for Thierry and his club at the 2013 TioMila

Thierry wins the O'ringen

He loves to cook

Thierry buys at least one cookery book per month. And when he is at home, he can easily spend 2 hours a day cooking! "It's probably my biggest passion at the moment, I find a lot of analogies with orienteering. A good recipe can enhance simple ingredients, in the same way that good planning can make an easy area interesting. "

His favorite neighbourhood is ... American

His favorite place is not Le Caylar (Hérault), Tromsø (Norway) or Lunsen (Sweden), but Manhattan (New York)! "It's hard to explain, but I love this city and how it feels. This is my favourite place for my end-of-season breaks. You have the impression that something happens on every street corner. "

10 Things...

He would like to open his own restaurant

His craziest dream would be to open a restaurant in Manhattan, in Chelsea or the Upper West Side, his two favourite neighbourhoods.

In 2013, he came face to face with a bear

Given the time that Thierry has run in forests, he has inevitably crossed the path of many animals: elk, kangaroos, wild boars ... but it was coming face to face with a Karelian bear that gave him the biggest adrenalin rush. It was during a training session in Finland in June 2013, when he was preparing for the world championships near Joensuu. On a slope and alone in the forest, he heard noise above him and thought that an elk was in the area. "I bent over to get a better view from under a fir tree. And there was a massive brown bear descending the slope in my direction! I will remember the face of that bear, as he started to turn away when he was 10 metres from me. He continued on his way at the same pace. My heart rate rose to 200 beats per minute, and I could not believe what had happened. Even though bears are numerous in North Karelia, it is extremely rare to see one. I can't say that I felt at ease for the rest of my training session ... "

He loves fishing

Since he was small, Thierry has loved fishing. Whether from a rock on the Var coast (his family had a small apartment in the Londe-sur-mer) or on a Finnish lake after a training session, he can spend hours fishing ... sometimes in vain! He likes to pretend that he is a great fisherman, but the fish can be reassured, it's usually to clear his head rather than to fill his plate.

...you don't know about Thierry

10 Things...

Central Park with Matthieu Puech, François

His most unusual prize: a 1.5m tree

Throughout his career, Thierry has accumulated a number of surprising and useless prizes. On the other hand, he says that Finland always provides very original prizes. Recently, at the national championships, he was given a 1.5m tree shrub ... perfect to fly home with! It ended up in the club coach's garden to go with the chainsaw that he won a few years earlier...

Thierry has common genes with Red (Angry Birds)

Thierry has always tried to use his frustration after a failure as a motivation. But in 2004, after the World Championships sprint, he tells us that he was most angry. "It was my first race at this championship. I finished in a relatively good fifth place, but only had made three controls from the finish had cost me the title. I was furious with myself. In private, when I returned to my hotel room, I exploded and turned my room upside down. I was completely crazy and hysterical. But I still had to run the middle distance for which I was the favourite. A few days later, I did celebrate my second World Champion title, but I can say that it would not have been the case if the sprint hadn't woken me up. "

Forever the first?

Thierry has undoubtedly won more titles than anyone in French orienteering. However, who remembers another runner who had the audacity to beat him in becoming the first French winner of a round of the World Cup? It was in 2002, 15 years ago, at a sprint in Brno in the Czech Republic that Damien Renard, Thierry's talented comrade from Pôle France, won his

first (and only) victory in the World Cup. Thierry had to wait almost 2 years before emulating him, and with 29 World Cup victories, he has certainly more than caught up.

Another honour that escaped Thierry is that of first French runner to become a Junior World Champion. This went to Lucas Basset who won the JWOC sprint title in Poland in 2011.

Thierry had to be satisfied with his long distance silver medal from JWOC 98 in France.

Give me a map and I'm magic!

Today, losing more than 30" on a leg happens to Thierry very rarely. But it was not always the case. In the summer of 1988, Michel Gueorgiou took

the France Junior team at Jicin in the Czech Republic. At the end of one of the training courses, Thierry went back into the forest without the map to collect in one of the last controls on the course, thinking that he would remember the exact location of the marker. Mistake. The aim of the exercise quickly changed from finding the control to finding his way back.

Also without a compass, Thierry chose a random direction and ran into a small village. He knocked at the first door he found and tried, using gestures, to explain the situation to the occupant. A few minutes and a grenadine later, he showed Thierry a local map of the area. More than an hour later, Thierry returned to the start, without the control marker but safe and The club, founded in 1975, has developed in line with our name: Nature - a respect for nature, Orienteering - which is our passion, and Saint-Etienne, where we live, a city with seven hills between Pilat and Forez and surrounded by countryside.

These values are those which Thierry has carried throughout his career and which he will continue to embody. With a character that is drawn to respect our natural environment, he has demonstrated virtues of commitment, respect and simplicity, to the orienteering world and has promoted the image of Saint-Etienne both outside the Loire and internationally.

The Club of his formative years

Club NOSE (4201AR) Licence n°167

By Olivier TARDY, Vice-President of NOSE, with thanks for contributions from some "elders" of the club. Photos taken & provided by Bernard MAGNE, former president of NOSE.

Thierry Gueorgiou, nicknamed "Thier" by the older members, or "Tero", has followed a path very close to the history of the club in which he developed, his "historic" club, Nature Orientation Saint-Etienne.

Thierry Gueorgiou

5 days of Bohemia, 1991

NOSE and Saint-Etienne

Thierry has also contributed, at the local level, to the recognition of our sport. For many years, the City of Saint-Etienne, the Department of the Loire and the Rhône-Alpes Region helped this exceptional athlete to achieve his objectives by giving him financial assistance. Thierry always came to meetings with these partners, even though his schedule and his races tended to keep him away from Saint-Étienne. In the town hall, we often heard the elected representatives or young sports-men admiring Thierry's results or, more recently, asking about his career overseas. Even the slag heaps, remnants of the coal mining era, remember the one who did not hesitate to run to their summits to see the sun rise over Saint-Etienne.

Thierry's career is closely linked with the history of NOSE. Under the guidance of his parents, Marie-Christine, President of the club, and Michel, Thierry joined NOSE in 1984 at the age of five along with his brother Rémi and was able to use the strong involvement of his family with the club to immerse himself in orienteering.

He participated in the development of NOSE and benefited from the training regime delivered by the club's coaches under Michel's leadership. He took part in sessions on Wednesday afternoons with UNSS, training sessions on Tuesdays, Thursdays and Saturdays, and high-level weekends, where he had to compete with older stars of the club. His training partners were brothers Gilles and Eric Perrin, Olivier Coupat, his brother Rémi, Pierre Linossier, Patrice Bornard, and many others. Areas like Le Pilat, Croix de Chaubouret, Sapt and Mount Chaussitre to the Jasserie, gave him the opportunity to hone his skills over the years. The map of Monts du Forez, less

5 days of Bohemia, 1991

to prepare for Scandinavian terrain. He also benefitted from the structure of NOSE and the know-how of coaches his father Michel, Georges Lagorce and Jean Garnier.

Results were not long in coming; in 1988 he became French Champion in the individual race at La Bresse. Thierry did not stop winning victories at regional and national level. He was, of course, challenged by high-level competitors, including François Gonon, his childhood friend, neighbour, training partner and comrade. The Allée Chantegrillet gifted France and the orienteering world two orienteers with great personal and sporting qualities.

The flying french man

Pretty soon, the "flying Frenchman" began to break through and his unrivaled technical ability was recognised. Bernard Magne, President of NOSE (1992-2007), recalls: "In 1991, NOSE organised its first major trip abroad to the 5 Days of Bohemia in parallel with WOC in Czechoslovakia. Several members of the club went on the trip including Thierry who won H12, one of his first international titles. I was particularly impressed when, on one of the races, all the competitors in H12 came out of the forest and followed the edge to reach their last control. All ... except one of them, our Thierry, who at twelve years old had already realised that he could cut across the field and gain precious seconds. We saw at that moment that he was certain to go far in his orienteering career!! "

The club of his formative years...

The club can count numerous individual, relay and Club (CFC -Championship of France for Clubs - an annual club relay competition) French championship wins. Thierry was a mainstay of the club's teams until his move to Sweden and was an integral part of NOSE's achievements which stand today at 14 CFC titles (since 1993) and 4 Challenges Bernard Stasi. The most recent 2016 and 2017 titles were won without him, thanks to a new generation that is following in his footsteps and benefiting from his example. Even when Thierry was pursuing his career focused on winning WOCs, he never hesitated to lend a hand to the club for the major team events such as the CFC and the CNE and to share his know-how with the younger and the "older" men of the club.

Club spirit

Tero strongly believes in "club spirit". It has allowed him to strengthen his competitive spirit whilst experiencing their solidarity and humility, but also family spirit. The "Noseux" (NOSE 42 club members) have fond memories of trips in the club bus, where friendships were made over analysis of maps or card games. Thierry was the master at motivating the troops with a video about the career of a cross-country or athletics champion or by playing the latest The Offspring album (to wake everyone up whilst travelling between the Formula 1 hotel and the race venue). He quickly became the person to emulate for runners of his generation, in both sporting and personal qualities.

Thierry has also brought this club spirit to the younger generation. He has been actively involved in their orienteering training, allo-

Nose 1998

on the bus home, presentations during the club's general meetings, or through more informal one-to-one discussions, Thierry has always gone out of his way to be interested in the members of the club, and to try pass on some of his experience. He also helped in the organisation of major events in the Loire including the federal week in 2005 with the departmental committee of the Loire and the 2008 French Club's Championship organised by NOSE during which he commentated from the bus podium. It was here that he agreed that a new race and trophy in his name could be added to this annual event to increase the number of competitors that could take part. Finally, in 2015, he appeared in the 30th anniversary book of the Loire department orienteering committee and its gallery of portraits of the champions and world champions from the Loire.

NOSE is extremely proud to count a champion like Thierry amongst its numbers. More than a champion, he is an icon in the history of our club and our city.

The "Noseux" want Thierry to come back and run as the "compulsory" veteran in the CFC or CNE relay team in the years to come, or even to run the weekend events on the Garagnas, he has always shown his affection and his attachment to

CFC 2008

CFC 2007

THIERRY GUEORGIU

Thank you for all for your support and encouragement over all these years!

It was always an enormous motivation to represent you through my performances and to demonstrate the French know-how! Continue to be proud of our sport, and to believe in the beauty of your dreams, always following the direction of your compass!

Looking forward to seeing you in the forest, map in hand!

“ “

Gueorgiou's story – Part I

Posted by Jan Kocbach, 27 Nov 2007@8:00

- One second mistake is still not good enough! This is what lies at the bottom of Thierry Gueorgiou's orienteering philosophy – which he shared with the participants at the Norwegian O-Gala in the middle of November. Based on Gueorgiou's two long presentations at the O-Gala, World of O presents a few short articles presenting some of the secrets behind Gueorgiou's success. Many thanks go to Gueorgiou for sharing his presentation slides.

Perfectionist

A good illustration of the perfectionist Gueorgiou is the following short story:

- When I started running for the Finnish club Kalevan Rasti, they laughed at me when they saw my control descriptions in which I put up 1 second mistakes [see illustration to the right]. But their attitude soon turned, and they started doing the same themselves. I am not satisfied until there are only zeros along the right edge of that control description.

And as everybody can see – Gueorgiou is getting closer and closer to his "all-zeros" goal.

Thierry Gueorgiou at the Norwegian O-Gala. Picture: Øystein Kvaal Østerbø

PASSIONATE about O'technique

Thierry Gueorgiou's father had an important role in Thierry's development as an orienteer. - No training without a map, was the philosophy. Even when running on the track, the map was there. Thierry's passion about O-technique is also mirrored in the new goal Thierry set after reaching his goal of becoming a World Champion in 2003: To become the best O'technician ever!

Thierry has increased his orienteering training from 170 hours in 1997 to 300 hours in 2007.

Following his fathers philosophy, between 40% and 50% of Thierry's training has been orienteering since 1997 – quite impressive compared to many others in the world orienteering elite. And also a result of Thierry's passion about O-technique.

Looking for example at the Norwegian elite, many are satisfied when they get above 20-25%. When looking at Thierry's training, Thierry has increased his orienteering training from 170 hours in 1997 to 300 hours in 2007. Below you see the development of orienteering training compared to other training between 1997 and 2007:

World Champion in his mind a hundred times

Over the years to come he continued becoming a World Champion in his mind.

At the World Orienteering Champs in France in 1987, Thierry's dream of being a world champion was born – at the age of 8.

In 1991 at the spectator races of the World Orienteering Champs in Czechoslovakia, Thierry got World Champion in his mind when winning the spectator race in his age category. Over the years to come he continued becoming a World Champion in his mind – playing it before his inner mind time after time.

the short distance in a close to mistake-free race, Thierry for the first time had to admit to himself that maybe he would not be a World Champion after all. - For the first time, I had to admit that my dream couldn't come true, are Thierry's words. This led to Thierry taking his longest break from orienteering ever – a break of several months. Out of this break came Thierry's rebirth as an orienteer: The "Full speed – no mistake" method – giving higher speed at lower risk. The "Full speed – no mistake" method will be the topic of the next article. - For the first time, I had to admit that my dream couldn't come true.

With this technique, Thierry regained his belief in becoming a World Champion – and the next one and a half years he won the 2003 World Championships in Trin, Switzerland over and over again in his mind. - The human brain makes no difference between reality and a mental picture. You have to feel that you are running in your garden. You have to feel that you have already run the World Orienteering Champs a hundred times, is Thierry's attitude. - It was "just once more becoming World Champion".

The ultimate proof about how realistic Thierry's mental picture of his winning the World Champs was: - When I ran into the finish as a World Champion in Trin in 2003, I was very happy – but not extremely happy. The reason: I had already seen this in my inner mind so many times before. It was "just once more becoming World Champion".

To be continued with ...

- The "Full speed – no mistake" method
- Rebirth as an orienteer: From "slow technique" to "higher speed @ lower risk"
- One general technique valid for all terrain types, mapping styles, ...
- They key: Visible & Isolated!
- - It is not on a great day you win the WOC, it is on an average day.
- Orienteering is a game
- Map examples

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- Webroute Forest Umbra: What would you choose?
- Exploiting the system
- Do not miss the good stories!
- Jukola preparations

- New design and site additions

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- Testing: New mobile version for iPhone/iPad/Android
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Gueorgiou's story – Part II

Posted by Jan Kocbach, 10 Dec 2007@8:00

- Thierry, you are one of the best map readers I have ever seen. But if you want to become the best, you must change your way of orienteering. You have to start building much simpler mental images of the terrain if you want to become faster. This was the message from Börje Vartiainen – Kalevan Rasti's coach – to Thierry Gueorgiou in the autumn of 2001, at a time when Gueorgiou was in his deepest valley yet as an orienteer.

WOC 2001: Breakdown of a dream

To recap from part I of this article series from Thierry Gueorgiou's presentation at the Norwegian O-gala – Thierry's "breakdown" was after a very disappointing 18th place at the short distance in the World Orienteering Champs in Finland in a close to mistake-free race. After many years of believing strongly that he could be the World Champion, Thierry had, for the first time, admitted to himself that maybe he would not be a World Champion after all (map example to the right – Vattula 2, WOC 2001, short distance final, Ari Anjala & Reijo Kujansuu).

- My technique is slow

Vartiainen's message helped Thierry onto the right track. - The 2002 season was my rebirth as an orienteer, Thierry comments. A new technique, a new attitude and mental preparations were the key elements in this process.

accurately and fast.

So what was the problem with the old technique? Let us take a look at one of Thierry's examples on a fantasy map (below) for an illustration of the old technique. Following along the drawn route choice, you read the map passing the marsh, then the tree root, the cliff, then between the two hills, cross the small track, then the small cliff, and so on. As an excellent map reader already at that time, Thierry read all these details accurately and fast – running in full control from feature to feature.

And the problem? Even if you run fast and orienteer fast – reading all details takes extra time.

I don't know if this is the right way to go, but it is a fact.

Thierry: - Maps get more and more detailed. I don't know if this is the right way to go, but it is a fact. My new orienteering technique had to account for this. Also, there are different mapping styles. Different mappers give very different maps. And there is a large range of different terrain types. I had to try to find a general method anyway.

Upper: Mapping evolution from 1982 to 2005 in WC Final 2006 area. Middle: 16 mappers – 16 maps – animated image from Olles.cz. Lower: Maps from different terrain types.

Visibility

It is obvious – and most orienteers make use of it in every race: Use the most visible and distinct features as key points in your orienteering. But how far do you go in your analysis of

visibility and distinctness of features? Do you analyze visibility and distinctness for all features before planning your route choice, and create a “visibility map” in your head?

Thierry [see map to the right]: - We can mark the areas from which we can see this control on the map. We can see the control from the hills, from this yellow area and from a part of the marsh.

But how far do you go in your analysis of visibility and distinctness of features?

These kinds of visibility maps are at the heart of Thierry’s new orienteering technique.

Another

map is for a large hill. Thierry again: - The stone you can see from only a very small area.

The hill you can see from a large area.

Map: Ruläys, Rauno Asikainen

Distinct features

- You must identify the remarkable features.

Thierry again: - The next question I asked myself is what is important on a map. For this question, there is no general answer. This is different from terrain type to terrain type. - You must identify the remarkable features. The features which are both isolated and visible!

Again – let’s use two of Thierry’s examples. The first example (to the left below) is for a special open French terrain with a lot of cliffs. As these cliffs are visible from far away, it would be tempting to base much of the orienteering on them. However, there is another set of details in this terrain type which are much more remarkable and isolated: Big characteristic trees (green ring on the map). The second example (Finnish terrain, to the right below) is very different. Here the cliffs are the remarkable and characteristic details which you can base your navigation on.

Left map: LES AUREDES, Pellegrin Alain & Laurent. Right map: TAHKOVAARA, Rauno Asikainen, Jussi Silvennoinen & Börje Vartiainen

In short: Don’t use stones as a basis for your navigation in an area full of stones.

- Sometimes a contour line can be really like a motorway.

Visible and distinct features

We are nearly there – but what about all those different terrain types? - Contour details like hills and depressions are visible and distinct in many terrain types – they are usually a very good to use for this technique, is Thierry’s tip to all the Norwegian listeners at the O-gala. - Sometimes a contour line can be really like a motorway. All you have to do is to follow it, Thierry commented the second leg on this years World Orienteering Champs middle distance. Further key points in all terrain types are (1) thrust your compass and (2) keep your head high. Also – and this is the main point – when using these visible and distinct features for your navigation, you can (and must) ignore all the other details. This is what makes you fast! (But don’t narrow the technique too much, or you will end up like Thierry Gueorgiou in the World Champs middle distance in 2006 – a miserable number four...)

“Full speed – no mistake”

Thierry: - The equation to solve is higher speed at lower risk. Piecing the above elements together, we arrive at what Thierry calls the “Full speed – no mistake” technique. Let us go back to the first example, and see how Thierry solves it with the “Full speed – no mistake” technique (map to the right). Thierry: - There is one perfect solution for every leg which you must find. The “Full speed – no mistake” technique helps you to find the optimal route choice. Runner A knows where he is – runner B knows where to go.

Let us analyze the leg and the two route choice alternatives using visibility maps (not shown explicitly). Along route choice alternative B, the visibility area for all three hills along the route choice is very good – so good that you can see from hill to hill, and maintaining full speed all

the way. Along route choice A, you can argue that the first hill/cliff along the route choice is distinct and visible from quite a large distance.

head from the physical map.

However, it is not visible from control number one, and thus lower speed and more orienteering is necessary for the first part of the leg. The next cliff you pass is again a nice, distinct feature, but visibility from the direction of the runner is rather limited. Visibility and distinctness for the rest of route choice A is also poorer than for route choice B.

See in 3D

What is needed to apply this technique effectively, is the ability to extremely fast get from the physical map to a visibility map for all distinct points in the terrain. To do this, you need to – again extremely fast – be able to visualize the terrain in 3D in your head from the physical map – as the 3D terrain model is the natural step to get from physical map to visibility map.

Master the technique

In the simple example above, this looks obvious. But let us take a look at a few of Thierry's examples which are not that obvious. Both are from the World Cup Final in 2006 in France (Map: AYDAT, O'vert4) – a terrain which nobody masters as well as Thierry Gueorgiou.

Here it is not that obvious which features are distinct and visible. At first look, everything looks just the same, and it is tempting to use the round cliff just left of the line as your attack-point for the control, as it (a) looks like a distinct feature and (b) you have a good entrance to the control over the small hill between the cliff and the control.

A small error in compass bearing can be tolerated, and maximum speed can be held until close to the control.

However, when we look at visibility maps (not shown), we see that the cliff is only visible from a small area, and you might miss it if your compass bearing is not very accurate. OK you could say – “Let us take the hill just behind the round cliff. That is larger, and my compass bearing needn't be that accurate.” But again visibility is an issue: Both the round cliff and the small hill to the right of the round cliff are “in the way”.

Let us take a look at Thierry's approach: The hill just to the right of the control (marked with three red rings in the right part of the above figure). Due to the large flat area south of the hill, the hill is visible from a large region along the route the runner is coming from. Thus, a small error in compass bearing can be tolerated, and maximum speed can be held until close to the control.

Below you see the second example from the World Cup Final. Again, visibility and distinctness is the key – this time for the hill to the right of the leg:

Training and attitude

Training yourself to master the method...

The “full speed – no mistake”-technique outlined above is one thing – and in itself you might say it is nothing special. Similar ideas lie behind most elite-orienteers technique – even if it might not always be spelled out this clearly regarding visibility maps and tactics. Training yourself to master the method, having the correct attitude and – last but not least – the mental aspect, is something completely different! More about this in the next article in this series.

- Webroute Forest Umbra: What would you choose?
- Exploiting the system
- Do not miss the good stories!
- Jukola preparations
- New design and site additions

Comments (5)

5 Comments to "Gueorgiou's story – Part II"

1. Jack says: December 11, 2007 at 21:43

Very good article :) I like the 'tips' and the ideas that Thierry sharing with us! Please give us more articles like this one! J.

2. AT says: December 13, 2007 at 13:17

These articles are great. Thank you very much for them Jan! Looking forward to reading next part.

3. KV says: December 16, 2007 at 21:38

Wow, great article! Cool method Thierry adopts. I'll try it out ;)

4. Soudy says: January 25, 2008 at 11:53

INCREDIBLE! That method looks really good. Think i'm gonna try it to.

5. -M- says: January 25, 2008 at 16:04

Are the visibility maps mentioned in the article shown somewhere in the internet? Very interesting way of thinking route choices!

Sorry, the comment form is closed at this time.

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"100 meters into the future" 7 sept.2004 - Très belle interview réalisée par le rédacteur en chef du magazine O-Sport, réalisée à l'issue du Chpt d'Europe 2004 au Danemark. Un Tero intime, qui revient en détails sur les tournants de sa jeune carrière et livre ici quelques-uns de ses secrets.

It is about two hours before the final banquet which will close the European Orienteering Championships in Denmark. Once again, Thierry Gueorgiou has outclassed the rest of the world in Middle Distance and has proven that, in this discipline, he is still dominant. I sit opposite to this young Frenchman in his hotel room, and we discuss Orienteering. For me, rather than making an interview, this seems to be the best Orienteering lecture I have ever been given. Questions flow out subconsciously and rather than a journalist I feel like an eager student who can't wait for more and more insights. Sometimes when Thierry describes his orienteering technique and his attitude towards the sport, I can't help being reminded of some superhuman cyber-orienteer (and this, in my mind, has only positive connotations). But, a sentence I will always remember is when he compares himself in 2001 (after what he considers the disappointing WOC in Tampere) to the present: "I would say that in 2001, I was an orienteer who knew all the time exactly where he was. At present, I'm an orienteer who knows where he will be in the next 100 meters."

Disastrous WOC 2001 in Tampere

Let's begin with your memories of WOC 2001 in Tampere, which you have said was very disappointing for you. Once you told me that, in 2000, you started to run for Kalevan Rasti and had been preparing for the WOC for a year. So what went wrong? Well, I didn't stay in Finland for the whole year, but I stayed there for a long time at many training camps. I felt very good about the terrain and well-prepared; but, somehow that was not reflected in my results. It was very frustrating. But, of course, now with a 3-year perspective, I can say that it was the breaking point in my Orienteering career. At first, I was so disappointed that I got very bored with Orienteering and did not even want to

think about the sport; but, with time, this somewhat dissipated, and I started to analyze what had gone wrong.

And what had gone wrong? Yea, a good question. To be honest, at first I could not come up with a clear answer for that. Well, the first thing was that, at that time, I was still very young, and not everyone can be like Pasi

Ikonen or Jörgen Rostrup and win his first World Champs at the age of 21. The second thing was that I needed to change my orienteering technique and that was very important.

You were not a good orienteer then?

Not exactly. I was a pretty good orienteer, but the problem was that Thierry at Tampere knew all the time exactly where he was.

At any moment, at any place, I could precisely show my position on the map. That was the main

problem. When you orienteer like that, you become very slow.

What I had to change was my mentality. I worked on being able to select the big and important features for my orienteering and not to read every single detail.

You said it took you a while to realize what was wrong?

So, when did you start working on this?

Over the winter after the WOC. It took me just about a month to retune my mind. In 2002, I was suddenly able to pick out the important features on the map and not to focus on everything.

And this was the breaking point for me.

Did you have to force your mind while training and to learn not to focus on every detail? Oh yes, which was very challenging and exhausting in a way especially because I was very comfortable with my previous orienteering technique, and knowing all the time where I was. And, of course, sometimes it may be very effective to orienteer like that; but, generally, this is not the fastest way, so I had to do something about it.

I see.

In my mind, Orienteering is a very simple sport. To each control is just one "correct" way. You just have to be able to see it and to run in it perfectly. What you have to learn is to know where

you want to go and why. And then you also have to learn to handle such things as stress, dealing

with weather conditions, and others, which affect also your performance.

So, what would you say is the biggest difference between Thierry in 2001 and Thierry today?

I would say that in 2001, I was an orienteer who knew all the time exactly where he was. At present, I'm an orienteer who knows where he will be in the next 100 meters.

So, you are all the time, in fact, running in the future? Yes, and that's very important. I may actually be running through a certain space; but, in my mind, I'm already some 200 meters ahead. All the time I try to keep my head up and to look for features as distant as possible. Moreover, in 2001 I was reading the features only when I passed them; so, I was not really running in the present, but in the past. I think this is the case with most not-so-good, young orienteers. They orienteer the way I did in 2001, and it's natural. This is very comfortable and far less challenging than the way I orienteer now. And, of course, you have to work really hard to change that.

Well, I would say I belong to this "past orienteering" group ' but, this reminds me of another thing I wanted to ask. Have you ever thought about how much time you spend reading a map during a race?

I would say it's becoming less and less. Maps now, for me, are so easy to understand that most of the time I just quickly look at them and go. Of course, I check it here and there, but the way is

usually so clear in my mind that it takes me just a second.

Two years after, at WOC 2003 in Switzerland

I still remember what you told me right after you had finished your victorious race in Middle Distance in Switzerland last year. You told me that, before this race, you had spent many hours training in the terrain and made, altogether, some two minutes of mistakes.

Yes, it's very important to feel relaxed before a race. I was very relaxed before this particular race because I knew it was almost impossible for me to make a mistake in that kind of terrain. I just told myself: This is what you have been training for and what you have been preparing yourself very well for. So, just enjoy. I think it will be quite similar in Västerås this year: I will feel very good about the terrain. Also, before Switzerland, I knew that everything had gone well for me over the two years prior, and I knew it was impossible that all of that would disappear on the day of the competition.

And then you finished, winning the World Championship title and beating silver Björn Valstad by almost 3 minutes. What was going through your mind?

To tell the truth, I was not that surprised. In fact, it was more like: OK, that's it. I mean, in my mind over the two years preceding the race, I had won it so many times that when it became reality I was not too surprised. In fact, I had a much better feeling after I won the Finnish Long Distance Champs last year. That was a real surprise, and something I still consider one of my greatest achievements.

What did you say to yourself after the WOC race?

Did you struggle to regain motivation for your training? For me, it is very important that Thierry in 2004 be better than Thierry

in 2003, and that I improve every single year. This is my main motivation. In my mind, I'm always imagining competitions between

Thierry 2002, Thierry 2003, Thierry 2004 ... But, the main point is that the Thierry of the present is better than the Thierry of the past.

Then results are not that important? I mean: Of course they are the ultimate thing which tells you what's what, but it's not that they mean everything to you, right?

Yes. But, in Switzerland, I was so well prepared for the race. I knew it. And when I managed to beat Norwegian team in our selection races, I got the necessary feedback.

It's still hard to describe the feeling I had during that race. I felt so well prepared, as if I were sitting for an exam and knew I had learned everything so that there was nothing that could surprise me. For me, in the forest it was as if someone had built a highway between the

controls. I couldn't make a mistake.

When I read the article in which you analyzed the race, it was clear that, for you, the key was to simplify the terrain as much as possible. What do you think will be the case in Middle Distance in Västerås this year?

It will be almost the same: the key is to be able to read only the big features. It will be a very challenging race, and runners will have to have a very good understanding of the map and be

able to make the right selection of features. And it will probably be even more difficult than in Trin last year, due to 2,5 contour interval.

You mentioned your positive attitude towards this race. I think this is the main difference between top runners' not how well they have trained, but how they are able to be up-and-ready on the day of a big event. Do you think you can train to do this or is it inborn?

If you want to be ready for just one race, like the Middle Distance in WOC, then physical shape is not so important. It's not a problem to be well fit physically for a single race. What is most important then is orienteering skill. Many runners make mistakes in important events. But, what is even more important is that, even if the race is the race you have been training for for a very long time, you have to be relaxed. Being relaxed is the key. For me, the WOC Middle Distance last year was just a normal day. I know that this may be difficult when you have been doing everything over two years with the aim of a race that you are just about to run, but being relaxed is so important. You have to do everything as if D-Day were just an ordinary day in your life.

But, is this possible to train to do it?

Yes, sure. It's a kind of attitude you have. Of course, when you are young and inexperienced, it is much more difficult to get this feeling. But, it is important to see that, even if you spoil the race, it is not the worst thing that can happen to you in life. There are many, many worse things that can happen to you. This is very important to realize. OK, I see.

I mean, you have to be able to imagine stopping your orienteering career the next day without

any big result. Would it mean that you had wasted your time training for something you never reached? No. You have to think about all the good moments you had while training and

competing. With me, I really enjoy every single competition, and I am grateful to have been given the chance to do this wonderful sport. This is what is really important, not simply the results. But,

of course, I would not have seen things quite in that way if you had asked me that about three

years ago. My attitude has changed significantly over the past few years.

So, this is something you now can do, something you were missing in Tampere 2001.

Sure it is. Now, the evening before every competition, I take a clean sheet of paper and

write down the race information, my schedule for the day, and also some key things for the race' like what to focus on and stuff like that. But, the biggest change is that I now also write: Enjoy! That is always there. It's a kind of game I play before every competition, and I like it very much. Relax and enjoy, and everything will be OK. I remember talking to Damien Renard last year before the WOC. He told me he was very uncertain about his shape because you had beaten him in every training, and that it is very difficult to beat you in training because you run at 100%. I know that it may, for other runners on our team, be a difficult situation; but, it is also difficult for me in a way. I know that now, in France, I'm the best, and that it would be so easy to be comfortable and just enjoy being "so good." In France, I'm presently No. 1, and people are always cheering me on; but, this is very dangerous. So, what I think about is which position I would have if I were, for example, on the Finnish team? And the answer is: I would have to fight for every single nomination. I can't be happy being the best in France. So, for me, it is very

important to always push at my maximum speed and maximum effort.

Do you think this victory also helped Orienteering in your country?

Well, I think the biggest help is that people can see that even a runner who does not live in Scandinavia can beat Scandinavians. I would say that all countries are looking up to Scandinavian Orienteering, and many think that it is almost impossible to beat runners from there. But, I have given them proof that it is possible and worth trying for. I think this is especially important for our youth runners. I

think that, if you are able to concentrate your efforts and fully devote yourself to the sport, it is possible to beat Scandinavians. Of course, if I were competing against them in 200 races, I would probably get beaten 140 times' but, in this important race, I was able to win.

Full-time orienteer

Now that you have won the main trophies in Middle Distance, do you want to try for something else, to prove that you can also do very well in say Long Distance?

Well, all the time there is something to improve, even in Middle Distance. For example, I have never won such an easy-and-fast course like the Middle Distance here in Denmark. So, all the time during the race, I kept asking myself: Am I fast enough? Will this speed be high enough? And I was really surprised when I came into the finish and heard that I was winning. So, every competition is different, and every single control is different.

In Orienteering, everything is a challenge.

Which do you consider more exciting, Middle or Long? Well, for me, Middle Distance means more adrenaline because there I can run full-speed all the time, which is still impossible for me in Long Distance. And, of course, it's a much better feeling

when you can afford to run full-speed from start to finish.

This sort of reminds me of something Lucie Böhm told me in an interview. She said after winning her WOC gold in Short Distance in Norway in 1997, she focused on Long Distance but never succeeded because she could not maintain full-concentration for 70 minutes of orienteering. Well, I don't know. I managed to win Long Distance Champs' in Finland last year,

which I consider one of my biggest successes. But, it's true that Long Distance is different. You need to have solid shape and be able to keep maximum speed for 90

minutes of running. I think that, if I compare myself to guys like Emil Wingstedt or Mats Haldin, I'm still not properly fit for that. You have to train very hard over many years in order to reach that level of fitness.

In Orienteering, it's very important to be relaxed during a race. And this is the case with me in

Middle Distance ' I'm always very relaxed before the start because I know that I'm very well prepared for this discipline. But, it's true that I don't have the same feeling for Long Distance

' yet :)

You've mentioned your victory at the Finnish Long Distance Championships last year, when you were able to beat all the Finnish runners in their home-terrain and to show that you have to be counted on as a potential threat for WOC medals, not only in Middle. Might this have also been a result of your preparations for WOC 2001, though it started to pay dividends two years after it was intended? Yes, definitely. It is very important to learn from disasters. In

fact, something similar happened to me at JWOC 1996 in Romania when I finished as 100-and-something and was very

disappointed. That was also a very good experience. Of course,

first I thought: Ok, I should stop my ambition to become a top orienteer. But then, it sort of changed to: Ok, what can I do to become better? I somewhat started my career over again with a clean slate. It's always very disappointing when you spoil your race and see other people who

have succeeded smiling and enjoying themselves ' but, it is also very important to absorb this feeling, to deal with it, and to mold it into something you will profit from in the future. Of course,

the feeling was very similar for me after yesterday's Long Distance in the EOC, when I was very

disappointed with my finish.

Last year, after Switzerland, you interrupted your Biology studies in order to be able to focus fully on Orienteering. Have you also increased your training, perhaps with the prospect of trying to run Long Distance in the WOC?

Yes, I wanted to be able to focus fully on Orienteering. Orienteering is my priority now, and will be so at least until Japan, which is my main goal. After my disappointing performance in Tampere, I started a four-year project which will finish with the WOC in Japan.

Why Japan?

Well, I think everybody will have equal chances there. It is sort of "unknown terrain" for all the top runners. It will be similar in this aspect to the WOC in the USA in 1993. But, this

year in Sweden, I think the Scandinavians will have a better chance to make good results since it

will be "very Scandinavian."

OK. But next year, when your four-year project comes to an end, you will still be very young ' you'll only be 27 ' which means you will still have your best years ahead of you. So, what's next?

True ' but, in 2006, the World Cup Final will be held in France, in very nice terrains; and, of course, the French hope WOC 2008 or 2009 to be staged in our country, which will, if it becomes

reality, be another nice challenge for me.

Do you still feel good? I mean sometimes, when runners do a thing like this, they tend to become overstrained, which is not the case with you? No. I feel very strong. My last serious injury is 3 year' s old and I stopped training only ten days.

I really do take care of having enough relaxation for my body. I control myself a lot and am very sensitive to my body' s signals. I think proper rest is even more important than proper training.

Maintaining the Human Databank

When you told me about being "in the future" in your orienteering, this involves plenty of visualization and interpretation of the map, doesn' t it? It' s not that you compare what you see with the map, but the map with what you see. Does reality correspond to your expectations such that you feel you are running through a well-known terrain?

Yes, almost 100%. I think every orienteer has some kind of databank in his head, a place where he stores experiences and memories of the races he has already run. So, when I see a hill on a map, I sort of fish into my memories and find a corresponding one. Of course, everybody' s databank is of a different size, depending on memory and also on the number of races run. But, some runners have in their banks only, for example, three Swedish knolls, two Danish knolls, and so on' others have hundreds. Mine is really big. Every hill or knoll or other feature I pass goes directly in my databank, and there I keep it stored.

So, when I see a little hill on a map here in Denmark, I sort of reconstruct it through my experience from the races and trainings I have had in local terrains. Almost all the time it more or less corresponds to reality.

And what you do when you pass something that does not look like you imagined it?

It is, of course, important to be flexible in your mind, and not to stick just to one feature and get fixated to it and upset when reality does not correspond to your expectations.

How much time do you spend thinking of new training methods and new training sessions?

A lot of time. For me, it is important not only to train my physical shape, but also to train a lot of orienteering technique. Everyday I train once or twice with a map. I always try to be focused and

to find the controls as fast as I can. I really enjoy Orienteering.

And how many hours a day would you say you spend thinking about

Orienteering? Oh, it' s quite a lot. I can' t tell you the number, but it' s a lot of time. In my mind, I

have lot of competitions where I, for example, imagine running the last kilometer against Mats Haldin in a big Relay in Finnish terrain. I always run this kind of mental

race, imagining a victorious situation. And, of course, all the time it' s me who is winning :-)

It' s very important to be positive in your mind. Even when I' m just jogging, I imagine these competition-like situations, but always in a very positive way.

Did this also help you during your last leg at Jukola? You said in your story that

almost all the time you were behind Emil and that, at the spectator-control, you were close to giving up.

Yes, I would say so. It was a very bad feeling for me throughout

the race, because I felt like I was in good shape but somehow not good enough to beat Emil.

It was so frustrating. I was very

disappointed because I don't like running behind anyone, just following; but, it was impossible to run in front of Emil at Jukola.

He was so fast. All I could do was read the map, follow Emil, and hope that the storm would pass.

But, what was really important was that I tried: Just try it, because you may not be given another chance. I think that nothing would have been worse than if I had said to myself, OK, so I will end up second; it's not so bad. Of course, giving up for a 2nd place would have been the easier solution, but I knew I would have been very angry with myself at the finish afterwards, just

because I would have known I had not tried hard enough.

In all events, it is really important to try and to give out your maximum.

Interview by Jan Skricka

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